SECOND NATURE

A roleplaying game about kids who become animals

VERSION 0.1 · DRAFT FOR PLAYTESTING

GAME DESIGN & WRITING

Richard Moore

FOR

3–5 players and a Storyteller, ages 10 and up

TYPEFACES

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This is a draft. The rules, the numbers and the pictures will change after playtesting. If something here doesn't work at your table, that's exactly what we want to hear about.

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PART ONE

Run Wild

Everything the players need: making a Bonded kid, rolling the dice, changing shape, and how a mission against the Gilded Hunt plays out.





CHAPTER 1

The Wild Wakes

The storm took the town's lights out at ten past nine. By half past, six kids who had never met were each staring into the eyes of an animal, and nothing was ever the same again.

YOU'RE AN ORDINARY KID IN AN ORDINARY TOWN, AND you can turn into an animal. Not any animal: **your** animal, the one that looked back at you on the night the Wild woke up. A jaguar on the wet roof of the garden centre. An owl on your windowsill. A coyote at the end of the street, waiting, as if it knew your name.

You didn't ask for it. Nobody chose you, nobody handed you a strange gadget, and nobody explained anything. The Wild simply woke in you, the way spring wakes a seed. And a few days later you found out why: somebody in town is hunting.

What This Game Is

Second Nature is a roleplaying game. One person is the **Storyteller**, who describes the world and plays everyone else in it. Everyone else plays one **Bonded** kid: a young person, aged 11 to 15, who can become one real animal. Together you tell the story of what happens when your group takes on **the Gilded Hunt**.

The Hunt is a secret society of rich, respectable people who hunt the Wild itself. For three hundred years they have trapped Bonded animals and worn their power as **Trophies**: a gold ring that gives a man a hawk's eyes, a brooch that lends a woman a wolf's nose. Now they are planning the **Last Hunt**, to chain the Old Wild for good. Every animal on Earth would come to heel. And after the animals, the people.

The Wild woke you to stop them.

How a Game Night Goes

Each session is one **mission**: a night when the team sneaks into one of the Hunt's places to free what's caged there, wreck what they've built, or steal back what they've taken. A mission takes two or three hours. You scout the place, pick a way in, get past what stands between you and the objective, and get out again before the Hunt catches your scent.

You can play one mission on its own, or play a **campaign**: about six missions in a row, building to the night of the Last Hunt (Chapter 8).

What Makes Your Kid

Every Bonded is built from three parts:

- **A frame:** the kind of animal you become, such as Big Cats, Birds or Critters. The frame gives your animal form its strengths and weaknesses.
- **An animal perk:** the special gift of your exact animal. A jaguar disappears into the dark; a raven can work a latch with its beak.
- **A human perk:** something you were good at before any of this. A football player still tackles like one when she's a bison.

You have one animal, for life. You won't collect others. Over a campaign your Bond grows deeper instead (Chapter 8).

What You Need

FOR THE FIRST NIGHT

- **Three to five players and a Storyteller.**
- **Six ordinary six-sided dice for each player** (no roll ever uses more than six), plus a few for the Storyteller.
- **About six small tokens per player** for Wild: beads, buttons, coins or counters.
- **A character sheet for each player** and **one mission tracker** for the table (Part Four), or the six ready-made Bonded in Chapter 18.
- **Pencils, and two or three hours.**

Setting up the first time takes under half an hour if you use the ready-made characters. Chapter 9 has a step-by-step first night for the Storyteller.

The Feel of the Game

Second Nature is for ages 10 and up. It's an adventure with real danger, like a good family adventure film. The Hunt is frightening, people get hurt, and things go wrong. But nobody in your group dies. The worst that can happen is being **Taken**: caught and caged by the Hunt. A Taken friend can be rescued, and in a campaign the rescue is often the best mission of all.

Changing shape is a wonder, and often a comedy. You can smell what the neighbours had for dinner. You can see in the dark. Your tail knocks a plant pot off the shelf. The book never treats the change as horror, and neither should your table.

TALK ABOUT IT FIRST

Before the first mission, spend two minutes agreeing what your table is happy to include. Is anyone scared of snakes or spiders? Should the Hunt be creepy, or more like cartoon villains? Chapter 9 has simple ways to check in and to pause a scene. Use them.

How to Read This Book

Part One (Chapters 1–8) is for everyone: making a character, rolling dice, shifting shape, missions, Clashes, and what happens when things go wrong. **Part Two** (Chapters 9–12) is for the Storyteller. **Part Three** (Chapters 13–17) holds five ready-made missions; players shouldn't read it. **Part Four** has ready-made characters, the rules on one page, and the sheets to print.

WORDS TO KNOW

- **Bonded:** a kid who can become their animal.
- **The Wild:** the living wildness in every animal; where your power comes from.
- **The Gilded Hunt:** the enemy. Its members are Huntsmen and Masters; its servants are Beaters, Hounds and Trappers.
- **Approach:** how you do something: Sneak, Force, Move, Sense or Wits.
- **Hit:** a die showing 5 or 6. **Difficulty:** the number of hits you need.
- **Wild:** your tokens, spent to shift, Push, Help and Patch Up.
- **Scent:** how close the Hunt is to finding you. When it reaches the **Limit**, the Hunt is Up.
- **Clash:** a fight.
- **Taken:** caught and caged by the Hunt.

A Taste of Play

EXAMPLE OF PLAY

Maya, Priya and Theo are inside Pemberton's Pets, where the Hunt is caging the town's strays. A Beater, a hired watchman, dozes by the counter in the dark.

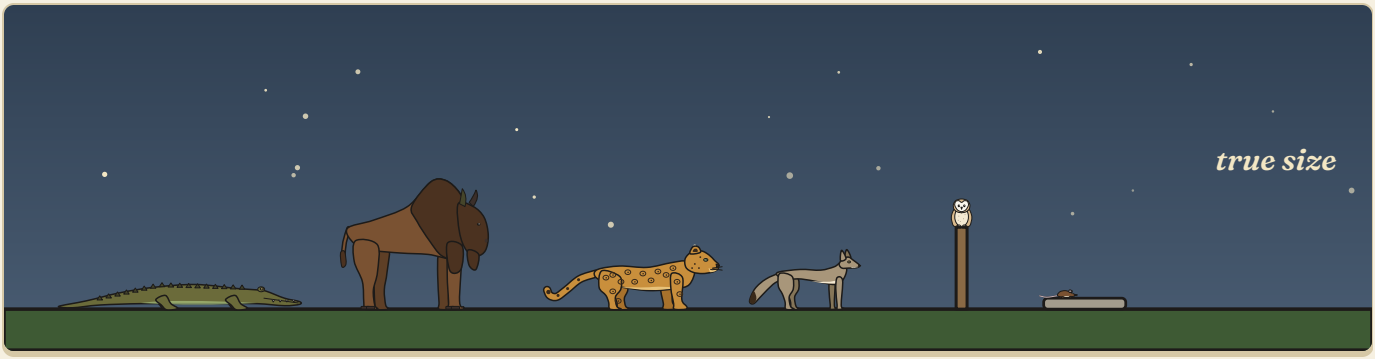
Storyteller: "The shop floor is dark. The watchman's chair creaks every time he breathes. It's Sneak, Difficulty 2, or Move, Difficulty 2. Everyone has to get past him. If anyone Fails, he wakes up."

Maya is already a jaguar. Her frame's Sneak is 4, Big Cats get +1 die in the Dark, and her jaguar's Night Rosettes lowers the Difficulty by 1. She rolls five dice against Difficulty 1 and gets 2, 3, 5, 6 and 1: two hits. A Success. She pads past without a sound.

Priya is a barn owl. Birds only have Sneak 2, but her owl's Silent Wings gives +1 die in the Dark, so she rolls three dice: 4, 5, 2. One hit against Difficulty 2 is a Partial. She's past, but her wingbeat stirs a stack of feed bags.

Theo is still human, because the office door ahead needs hands. His Sneak is only 1, so Maya spends 1 Wild to Help: "I creep back and nudge him towards the quiet floorboards." Theo rolls two dice and gets 5 and 5: a Success.

Everyone is past. One Partial means the obstacle raises the Hunt's Scent by 1 as it ends (Chapter 5). The watchman sleeps on.



CHAPTER 2

Making Your Bonded

MAKING A CHARACTER TAKES ABOUT TEN MINUTES. You choose (or roll for) your animal, decide what you're good at as a person, and pick one small thing that shows in both your shapes. If you'd rather start straight away, take one of the six ready-made Bonded in Chapter 18.

MAKING A CHARACTER, STEP BY STEP

1. **Frame and animal.** Choose them, or roll a d6 for your frame (the table below) and a d6 for your animal: 1–2 is the first animal listed, 3–4 the second, 5–6 the third. No two characters in a group have the same animal. If two players want the same one, they each roll a die and the higher roll gets it; the other picks again (they can keep the same frame).
2. **Human ratings.** Put 3, 2, 2, 1 and 1 into Sneak, Force, Move, Sense and Wits.
3. **Human perk.** Choose one, or roll two d6.
4. **Your Mark.** One feature that shows in both forms.
5. **The rest.** A name, an age (11 to 15), and something you love about your town. Start every mission with 4 Wild and 0 Hurt.

The Five Approaches

Everything you try is done with one of five **approaches**. Each has a **rating** from 0 to 4: the number of dice you roll.

APPROACH	WHAT IT COVERS
Sneak	Hiding, stalking, slipping past, staying unseen.
Force	Fighting, breaking, shoving, scaring.
Move	Running, climbing, jumping, flying, swimming.
Sense	Noticing, tracking, searching, scouting.
Wits	Talking, planning out loud, using tools and machines, reading. Human form only.

You have two sets of ratings. As a **human**, you use the five you chose in step 2. As an **animal**, you use your frame's ratings instead, and your Wits is 0: animals can't talk, read or use tools.

Places and Their Tags

Every place in a mission has one or more **tags**. Tags are how the world tells you which animals are at home there.

TAG	WHAT IT MEANS
Dark	Unlit or night-black: alleys, cellars, the woods at midnight.
High	Rooftops, walls, trees, beams and ledges.
Narrow	Vents, pipes, crawlspaces, gaps under doors.
Water	Rivers, moats, drains, pools.
Open	Lawns, car parks, fields: wide spaces with no cover.
Crowd	People around, who will notice an animal that doesn't belong.
Locked	Doors, cages, latches and machines.

In animal form, if any of your frame's **Strengths** is among the place's tags, you get **+1 die**. If any of its **Weaknesses** is, the roll is at **+1 Difficulty**. It's one die and one step at most, however many tags match. If a place has both a Strength and a Weakness of yours, both apply. In human form, tags don't change your roll.

The Six Frames

Your frame is the kind of animal you become. Your animal is its real size: a moose is as big as a car and a mouse fits in a shoe. Roll a d6 or choose.

D6	FRAME	SNEAK	FORCE	MOVE	SENSE	STRENGTHS (+1 DIE)	WEAKNESSES (+1 DIFFICULTY)
1	Big Cats	4	3	3	2	Dark, High	Water, Crowd
2	Canines	3	3	3	4	Open, Crowd	High
3	Birds	2	1	4	4	High, Open	Narrow
4	Critters	4	1	3	3	Narrow, Crowd	Open
5	Heavies	2	4	3	3	Open, Locked	Narrow, Crowd
6	Reptiles	3	3	3	3	Water, Dark	Crowd

Animal-form Wits is always 0. Animal perks work only in animal form.

Big Cats



"You won't hear me. You won't see me. Then I'm on the shelf above your head."

The best sneaks in the game, and good in a fight. Big Cats own the dark and the rooftops, but they hate water and they can't blend into a crowd: people scream when a jaguar walks into the shop.

JAGUAR · NIGHT ROSETTES
In Dark places, your Sneak rolls are at –1 Difficulty.

SNOW LEOPARD · AMBUSH
Your first Strike in each Clash is at –1 Difficulty.

CHEETAH · BURST
Once per scene, Push a Move roll without spending Wild.

Canines



"I smelled them before you saw them. They went that way. Come on!"

The best noses in the game, and solid at everything else. Canines run well in the open and pass for somebody's dog in a crowd, but they're no climbers.

COYOTE · PACK
Once per scene, Help without spending Wild.

SHEPHERD DOG · GOOD DOG
In Crowds, your Sneak and Sense rolls are at –1 Difficulty. People see a dog, not you.

RED FOX · WILY
Once per scene, when your roll Fails, it becomes a Partial instead.

Birds



"From up here I can see the whole yard, the guard, the van, and the way out."

Fast, far-sighted scouts who fly over walls and see everything from above. Birds are no good in a fight and hate tight spaces where they can't open their wings.

PEREGRINE FALCON · KEEN EYES
In Open or High places, your Sense rolls are at –1 Difficulty.

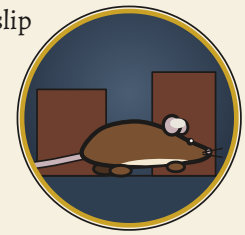
BARN OWL · SILENT WINGS
In Dark places, +1 die on Sneak and Move rolls.

RAVEN · CLEVER BEAK
Against Locked things you can roll Wits in animal form, with a rating of 2, to work latches, keys and switches. You still can't talk.

Critters

"Nobody looks down. That's the whole trick."

Tiny, quick and everywhere. Critters slip through gaps nothing else fits through and scurry unnoticed under a crowd's feet. Out in the open, everything wants to eat them, and they can't fight at all.



HOUSE MOUSE · TINY
In Narrow places, your Sneak and Move rolls are at –1 Difficulty.

BROWN RAT · GNAW
Against Locked things, your Force rating is 3.

GREY SQUIRREL · LEAPER
In High places, your Move rolls are at –1 Difficulty.

Heavies



"There was a door. There isn't now."

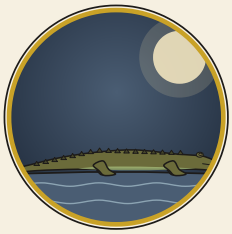
Huge and strong. Heavies break locks by breaking whatever the lock was attached to, and nothing stops them in the open. They don't fit through anything narrow, and a bison in a crowd is not subtle.

BISON · SHAGGY COAT
Once per scene, when you'd take Hurt, take 1 less.

MOOSE · ANTLER SWEEP
Once per scene, when your Strike against a Beater or Hound Succeeds, it's out at once.

HIPPOPOTAMUS · CHARGE
Once per scene, when a Force roll Succeeds, it counts as a Critical.

Reptiles



"I can wait. I can wait all night."

Patient all-rounders who are at their best in water and in the dark. People panic when a reptile turns up in a crowd.

ALLIGATOR · LURKER
In Water, your Sneak and Force rolls are at –1 Difficulty.

PYTHON · COIL
When your Strike Succeeds, the next roll anyone makes against that threat this Clash is at –1 Difficulty.

KOMODO DRAGON · TASTE THE AIR
+1 die on Sense rolls, and a Hound's Tracker doesn't affect you.

Human Perks

Your human perk is something you were good at before the Wild woke you, and it stays with you in both forms. Every perk works in any form unless it says otherwise. A perk's extra die counts towards the Cap (Chapter 3). Choose one, or roll two d6: the first die picks the list (1–3 for A, 4–6 for B) and the second picks the row. Two players may have the same human perk.

2ND DIE	A (FIRST DIE 1–3)	B (FIRST DIE 4–6)
1	**Football Player:** +1 die on Force rolls.	**Team Captain:** the team starts every mission with 1 Edge.
2	**Hide-and-Seek Champ:** +1 die on Sneak rolls.	**Animal Whisperer:** +1 die on rolls against Hounds, or to get past an obstacle they guard.
3	**Track Star:** +1 die on Move rolls.	**Swim Team:** +1 die on rolls in Water.
4	**Scout:** +1 die on Sense rolls.	**Gymnast:** +1 die on rolls in High places.
5	**Brainiac** (human form): +1 die on Wits rolls.	**Night Owl:** +1 die on rolls in Dark places.
6	**Gamer:** start every mission with 1 extra Wild.	**Drama Kid:** +1 die on rolls in Crowds.

Your Mark

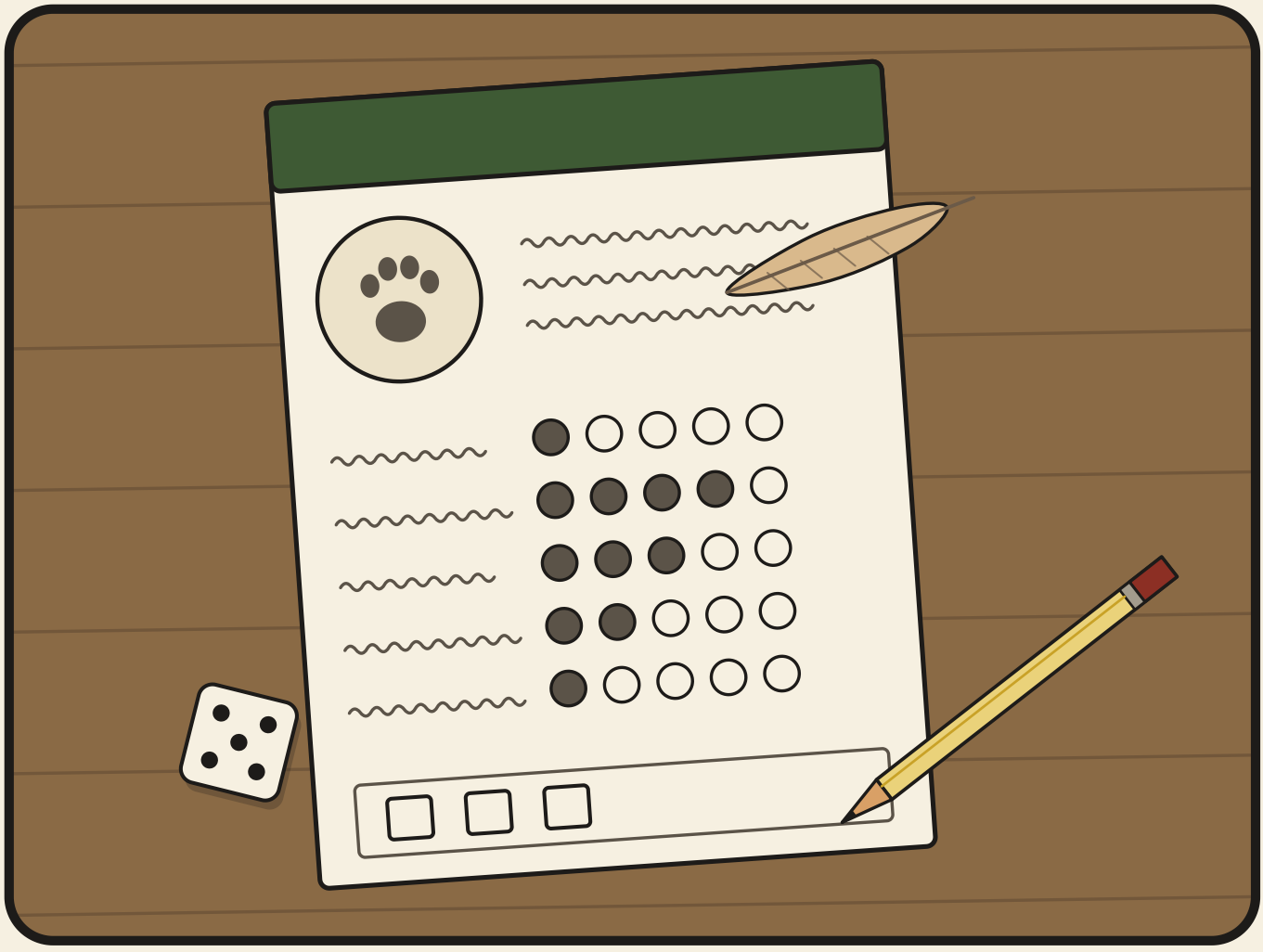
Your **Mark** is the one thing about you that shows in both shapes: a freckled nose that becomes pale spots on a snout, a white streak of hair that becomes a white patch of fur, a scar through an eyebrow. Friends use it to tell which animal is you. So does the Hunt: when they learn your Mark, you're **Exposed** (Chapter 7).

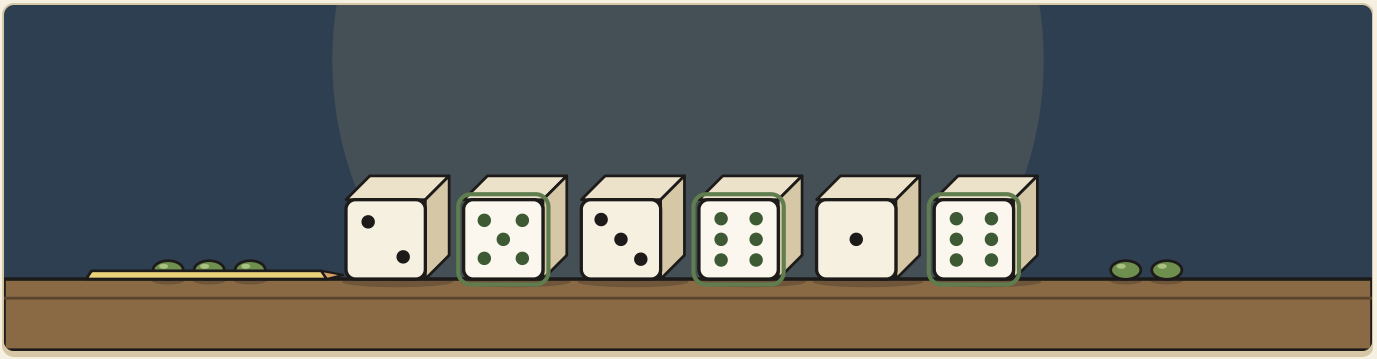
Wild and Hurt

You start every mission with **4 Wild** tokens (5 with the Gamer perk) and **0 Hurt**, with 3 Hurt boxes on your sheet. Wild is the fuel for everything special you do (Chapter 3). Spend it. Any you don't spend is lost when the mission ends.

EXAMPLE: MAKING LUCÍA

Lucía's player rolls a 6 for her frame: Reptiles. Her animal die is a 2, the first animal listed, so she's an **alligator**. She puts Sneak 2, Force 1, Move 3, Sense 1, Wits 2 for her human ratings: a fast swimmer and a fast talker. For her perk she rolls 4 and 3: list B, row 3, **Swim Team**. That gives +1 die on rolls in Water in either form, which suits an alligator very well. Her Mark is the freckles across her nose; as an alligator, they're a spray of pale spots on her snout. She loves the river path behind the old mill.





CHAPTER 3

Rolling the Dice

Most of the time you just say what your character does, and it happens. You roll only when it's risky and could go either way: sneaking past a guard, leaping a gap, breaking open a cage. Every roll in the game works the same way.

THE ROLL

Roll as many d6 as your **rating** in the approach you're using, in your current form, plus any bonus dice. Every **5 or 6 is a hit**. The **Difficulty**, from 1 to 4, is the number of hits you need.

- **Fail:** no hits at all.
- **Partial:** at least one hit, but fewer than the Difficulty. You do it, but it costs you something.
- **Success:** hits equal to or more than the Difficulty.
- **Critical:** a Success with two or more 6s among the dice.

At Difficulty 1, a single hit is a Success, so there's no Partial. If your rating in an approach is 0, you can't roll it: an animal can't roll Wits, for instance. The Storyteller says which approaches work for a problem and the Difficulty of each. Usually there's more than one way.

Nobody rolls against you. The Storyteller never rolls dice. Guards, Hounds and locks just have a Difficulty, and what they do to you happens when you Fail or get a Partial.

The Cap

Bonus dice come from lots of places: Strengths, perks, friends' Help and Edges. Some things lower the Difficulty instead. But they don't pile up forever.

THE CAP

From all sources together, one roll gets at most **+2 dice** and at most **–1 Difficulty**. Difficulty never goes below 1.

Things that make a roll harder, like a Weakness or a Hound's Tracker, aren't limited by the Cap, so a Difficulty can go above 4.

Wild

Wild is the power of your Bond, kept as tokens in front of you. You start each mission with 4. Spend 1 Wild to:

- **Shift** into your animal (Chapter 4).
- **Push** a roll you just made.
- **Help** a friend's roll.
- **Patch Up** 1 Hurt (Chapter 7).

Unspent Wild is lost when the mission ends. Teams that hold their Wild back for later lose far more often than teams that spend it.

PUSH

PUSH

After you roll, you may spend 1 Wild to reroll every die that didn't hit. Keep the new result. You can Push a roll only once. A Push isn't a bonus die, so the Cap doesn't limit it.

HELP

HELP

When a friend at the same obstacle is about to roll, you may spend 1 Wild to give them **+1 die**. Say how you help. Helping doesn't use your action, so you can Help and still act yourself. It has to be something your current form can do: in animal form you can't help with Wits. Help counts towards the Cap, so at most two friends can usefully Help one roll.

Edges

An **Edge** is a lucky break the whole team shares. You gain Edges from a Critical when the extra progress isn't needed (Chapter 5), from a good scouting roll (Chapter 5), and from the Team Captain perk. Spend an Edge for +1 die on anyone's roll; it counts towards the Cap. The team holds at most 2 Edges at a time; any more are lost.

Order of Things

When a roll happens, the result comes first, then its cost, then everything else. If a Partial both finishes a job and raises the Hunt's Scent to its Limit, the job is still done before the Hunt comes running (Chapter 5).

The Odds

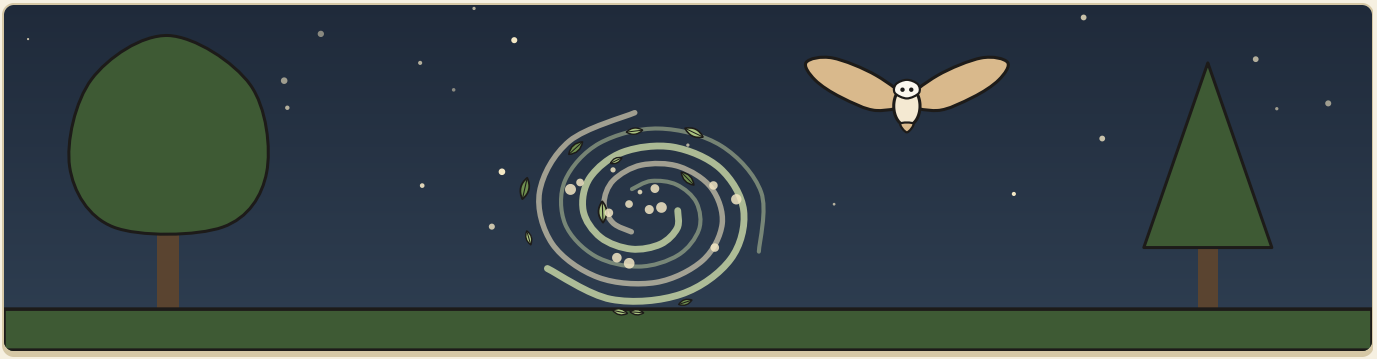
These are the chances for a single roll before any Push. Pushing a Fail rerolls every die, so it's a whole second chance.

DICE	AT LEAST A PARTIAL	SUCCESS AT DIFFICULTY 1	AT 2	AT 3	TWO OR MORE 6S
1	33%	33%	—	—	—
2	56%	56%	11%	—	3%
3	70%	70%	26%	4%	7%
4	80%	80%	41%	11%	13%
5	87%	87%	54%	21%	20%
6	91%	91%	65%	32%	26%

The lesson: you'll nearly always get somewhere, but clean Successes against Difficulty 2 or 3 need a good pool, a Strength, a friend's Help, or a Push.

EXAMPLE: A PUSH AND A HELP

Jonah, as a bison, needs to break the bars of a cage: Force, Difficulty 3. Bison Force is 4. Heavies are strong against Locked things (+1 die), and his Football Player perk adds another (+1 die). Theo offers to Help, but Jonah is already at the Cap of +2 dice, so Theo keeps his Wild. Jonah rolls six dice and gets 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 and 6: two hits, a Partial. He spends 1 Wild to Push and rerolls the four misses: 6, 2, 5, 1. That's two more hits, four in all, with two 6s. A Critical!



CHAPTER 4

Shifting

It feels like jumping into cold water and coming up as somebody else, except the somebody else is still you.

When you shift, the Wild wraps around you in a swirl of light and leaves, and a moment later the animal steps out. Nobody sees the in-between, not even you. One second there's a kid; the next there's a barn owl blinking on the fence post, wearing that kid's freckles.

SHIFTING

- **Shifting into your animal** costs **1 Wild** and takes your action.
- **Out of Wild?** You can still shift into your animal by taking 1 Hurt instead, unless that would put you Down.
- **Shifting back** to human costs nothing, but it also takes your action.
- **There's no time limit.** Stay an animal all night if you like.

When You Can Shift

Shifting takes your action, so you can shift instead of rolling in a round (Chapter 5). And as you move from one obstacle to the next, everyone may Shift or Patch Up once without it using an action. Most shifts happen there, in the gaps between obstacles.

Being Seen

IN SIGHT OF THE HUNT

Between obstacles you can always find cover, so a shift there is out of sight, unless the mission says you're being watched. A shift during a Clash is always in sight. If the Hunt sees you shift, its Scent rises by 1 (in a Clash, the Clash's own rise covers it: Chapter 6), and you're **Exposed** (Chapter 7).

What Comes With You

- **Your Hurt** comes with you. A bruised kid is a bruised fox.
- **Your Wild** is yours in either form.
- **Your human perk** works in both forms, unless it says human form. You're still you in there.
- **Your clothes and small personal things** (phone, glasses, keys) vanish into the Wild and come back when you do.
- **Anything else you're holding** drops at your feet when you shift. That includes the prize you came to steal.

Being an Animal

In animal form you use your frame's ratings and your Strengths and Weaknesses (Chapter 2). You're the real animal at its real size, with its real senses. You also lose some things:

- **You can't speak, read, or use hands or tools.** Your Wits rating is 0, so you can't roll Wits, or Help a friend's Wits roll. (The Raven's Clever Beak is the one exception, against Locked things.)

- **You can carry one small thing** in your jaws, beak or claws: a key, a Trophy, a note.
- **You can't talk to your friends.** Bonded don't share thoughts. Agree on simple signals before a mission: one bark means danger, a tap on the glass means "here". At the table, of course, the players can talk as much as they like.

Human or Animal?

Shifting is never free, and staying an animal isn't always best. Before each obstacle, look at what you'll need:

- **Locked doors and people to talk to** need Wits, and Wits needs human form.
- **Crowds** are a Weakness for Big Cats, Heavies and Reptiles. A kid in a crowd is invisible; a jaguar is not.
- **Your Weaknesses** can make a human roll the better bet. A cat at the moat might do better swimming as a kid.
- **Everything physical**, like sneaking, climbing, fighting and tracking, is usually better as an animal.

A good team spreads out: one or two stay human for the doors and the talking while the others go wild.

Stuck

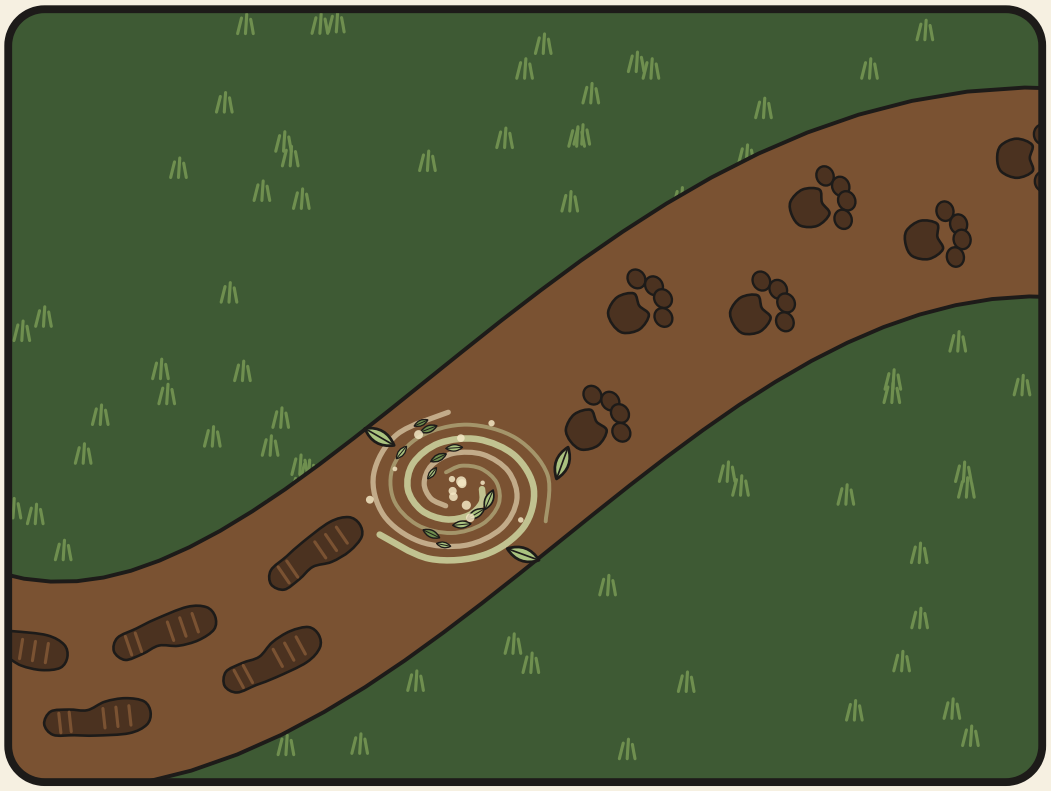
If you go **Down** while in animal form (Chapter 7), the Wild holds on to you: you're **Stuck** as your animal until the mission ends. You can't shift back until then. Getting a moose home through town without being seen makes a fine scene for the end of the night.

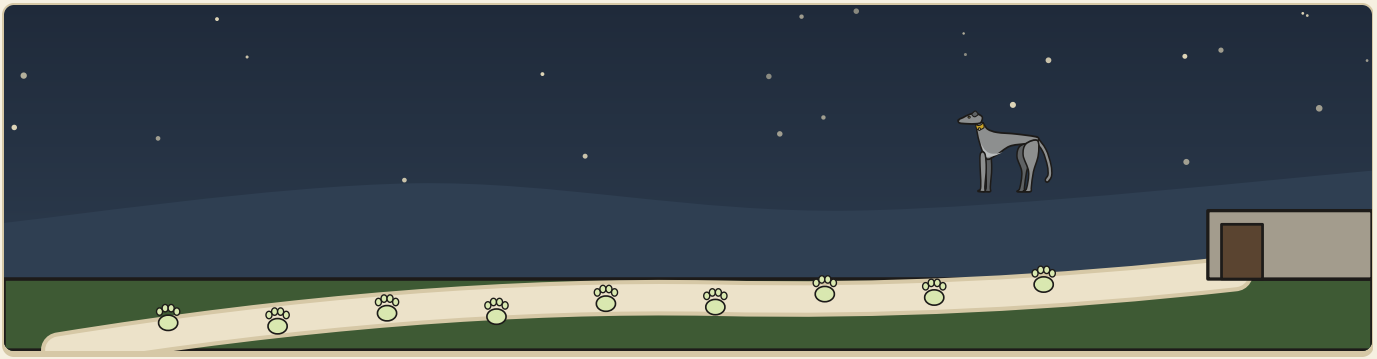
EXAMPLE: CHOOSING FORMS

The team reaches the loading bay of the museum: Dark and Locked, with Wits Difficulty 2, Force 3 or Sneak 3. Priya stays human for it: her Wits is 3 and her Brainiac perk adds a die. Jonah shifts into his bison on the way, which costs him 1 Wild but no action: Bison Force 4 plus 1 for Locked. Maya stays a jaguar, ready for the dark halls beyond. Priya rolls Wits with four dice. Jonah can't Help a Wits roll as a bison, but if her roll goes badly, he can take the next round and roll Force against the shutter with five dice.

DESIGNER'S NOTE

There's no countdown on your animal form, and nothing bad happens if you stay too long. The cost of the Wild is paid going in: a token, an action, and everything an animal can't do. That keeps the choice simple at the table: "Is it worth a Wild to be a bear for this?"





CHAPTER 5

Missions and the Hunt's Scent

A mission is one night's work against the Hunt: get in, do the job, get out. The Hunt can smell the Wild. Every slip you make brings them closer, and if they catch your scent before you're out, the Masters come running.

The Shape of a Mission

1. **The brief.** The Storyteller tells you what the Hunt is up to and what you need to do.
2. **Scouting.** One of you scouts the place.
3. **The way in.** Every mission has two ways in. Scouting decides who picks.
4. **Obstacles.** Two to four of them stand between you and the objective.
5. **The objective.** Free them, wreck it, or steal it.
6. **The Escape.** One or two obstacles on the way out.
7. **The result.** Win, Costly Win or Loss.

Players see the mission map and the two ways in. You learn an obstacle's approaches and Difficulties when you reach it.

Time

- **A round** is everyone getting one action: one roll, a shift, a Patch Up, or freeing a friend.
- **A scene** is one obstacle, or one Clash. "Once per scene" abilities come back at the start of every scene.
- **A mission** is the whole night.

Moving from one obstacle to the next is free, and on the way everyone may Shift or Patch Up once without using an action.

Scouting

SCOUTING

Before going in, one character rolls Sense against the mission's scouting Difficulty (2 in every mission in this book). Shifting to scout is out of sight, as it is between obstacles; it still costs Wild. Friends may Help.

- **Critical:** the team picks the way in and gains **two Edges**.
- **Success:** the team picks the way in and gains **an Edge**.
- **Partial:** the team picks the way in, but **Scent starts at 1**.
- **Fail:** the Storyteller picks the way in, and **Scent starts at 1**.

Obstacles

An **obstacle** is anything that stands in your way: a guarded gate, a locked door, a dark hall full of Hounds. Each one lists:

- its **tags** (Dark, High, Narrow, Water, Open, Crowd, Locked);
- the **approaches** that work, with a **Difficulty** for each;
- whether it's a **point** or a **group** obstacle, and the **progress** a point obstacle needs;
- whether it's **guarded** (and by whom) or **dangerous**.

POINT OBSTACLES

One person can deal with it for everyone: a door to unlock, a path to find. Each round, **one character rolls** (any one of you, and it can be someone different each round) and the others may Help. Progress adds up until the obstacle is cleared, then everyone goes through.

GROUP OBSTACLES

Everyone has to get past it: a yard to sneak across, a wall to climb. Each round, **everyone who isn't past yet rolls**, and each gets past on their own Partial or better. Those already past can still Help. When everyone is past, the obstacle is done.

RESULTS AT AN OBSTACLE

- **Success:** 1 progress (or, at a group obstacle, you're past).
- **Critical:** as a Success, plus 1 extra progress. If the extra isn't needed (always so at a group obstacle), the team gains an Edge instead.
- **Partial:** as a Success, but **Scent +1**.
- **Fail:** no progress (you're not past), and **Scent +1**. A **dangerous** obstacle also deals 1 Hurt to whoever Failed.

At a group obstacle, Scent rises once, when the obstacle ends: +1 if anyone got a Partial or a Fail. If anyone still isn't past after the third round, Scent also rises by 1 at the end of every round after that.

In the Escape, Partials cost no Scent. Only Fails count.

GUARDED OBSTACLES

Some obstacles have guards: Beaters, Hounds, Trappers or a Huntsman. **A Fail at a guarded obstacle starts a Clash** with the guards (Chapter 6). You can also choose to start the Clash yourselves, before anyone rolls. If you beat the guards (or they pull back after round 4), the obstacle is cleared, unless it says progress is still needed. In that case you carry on rolling for progress, without the guards.

Scent

The Hunt's **Scent** is how close they are to finding you. Track it on the mission tracker, from 0 up to the mission's **Limit**. Each mission gives its Limit for 3, 4 and 5 players.

SCENT

- **It rises** for Partials and Fails at obstacles, once at the end of each Clash, for a shift the Hunt can see, and for a poor scouting roll. Nothing else raises it.
- **It never goes down.** The Limit never changes during a mission.
- **On the Trail:** if, when an Escape obstacle begins, Scent is at least half the Limit (round up), that Escape obstacle is at +1 Difficulty for every approach.
- **The Hunt is Up** when Scent reaches the Limit. Any Scent past the Limit is lost.

The Hunt Is Up

When Scent reaches the Limit, horns sound across the dark, and the **Masters** of the Hunt arrive. Nobody fights a Master. You run.

WHEN THE HUNT IS UP

- Finish resolving the roll that did it. If that roll finished the objective, it's finished.
- From now on, **any Fail means you're Taken**, wherever you are. A Fail at a guarded obstacle doesn't start a Clash any more: you're just Taken.
- Anyone still Down or Netted when the scene ends is Taken.
- If the objective isn't done, the team chooses: **keep going**, or **Withdraw** straight to the Escape (a Loss).
- If you're already in the Escape, carry on.

ADVICE: PRESS ON OR RUN?

Press on only if you're already working on the objective. Run the moment a friend is Taken. A Loss can be put right later. A whole team caught at the cage can't.

The Objective and the Prize

The objective is an obstacle like any other: usually a point obstacle needing 2 or 3 progress, sometimes guarded. When it's done, the job's done and you head for the Escape.

Some objectives are a **prize to steal**, like a Trophy or a ledger. One character carries it, in hand or in jaws. Handing it to a friend at the same obstacle takes your action, with no roll. If you shift, it drops at your feet and someone has to pick it up. **If the carrier is Taken, the prize is lost**, and so is the objective.

Withdrawing

The team may **Withdraw** at any time: give up on the objective and go straight to the Escape. The mission is a Loss, but you live to fight another night.

The Escape

The Escape is one or two group obstacles on the way out. Everyone still free must get past them. Partials cost no Scent here, but Fails do, and if the Hunt is Up, a Fail means you're Taken. When everyone still free is past the last Escape obstacle, the mission ends.

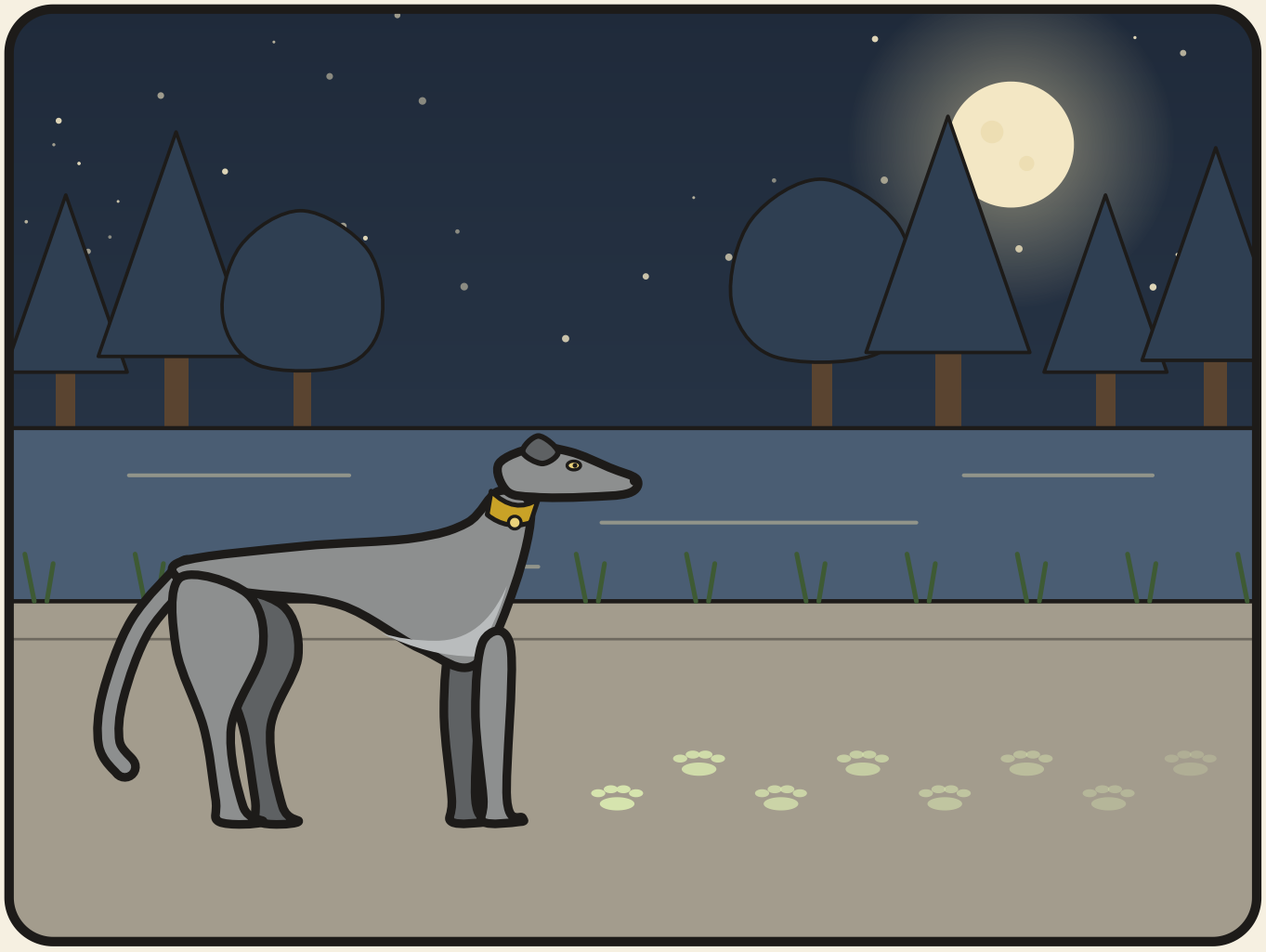
How It Ends

RESULT	WHEN
Win	The objective is done and nobody is Taken.
Costly Win	The objective is done, but someone is Taken.
Loss	The objective isn't done: you Withdrew, the prize was lost, or everyone was Taken.

In a campaign, the result moves the Hunt track (Chapter 8).

EXAMPLE: THE HUNT IS UP AT THE CAGES

The team is at the cages in Pemberton's Pets: Wits 2 or Force 3, 3 progress. The Limit for four players is 6, and Scent is already 5. They have 2 progress. Priya rolls Wits and gets a Partial: 1 progress, the cages spring open, and Scent +1 reaches the Limit. The result comes first, so the cages are open before the Hunt is Up. Horns sound outside. The objective is done, so there's no choice to make: run! In the Escape, every Fail now means Taken, so the team spends every Wild token it has left on Help and Pushes.





CHAPTER 6

Clashes

SOMETIMES SNEAKING FAILS, AND SOMETIMES A WALL of grey Hounds just won't let you by. A **Clash** is a fight: quick, loud, and over in a few rounds. Clashes are noisy, so the Hunt always hears them.

Threats

Everyone you fight is a **threat** with three numbers:

- **Difficulty:** the hits you need to land a blow on it, slip it, or distract it.
- **Toughness:** how much harm it takes before it's out (knocked down, chased off or tied up).
- **Harm:** how much Hurt it deals to you.

Some threats also have a special rule. All of them are in Chapter 10. Threats never roll; they hurt you when you slip up.

A Round of a Clash

Each round, everyone in the Clash takes one action, in any order the players like:

CLASH ACTIONS

- **Strike** (Force) a threat. Success: 1 harm. Critical: 2 harm. When a threat has taken harm equal to its Toughness, it's out.
- **Distract** (Sneak or Move) a threat. A Success puts the next Strike against it this round at –1 Difficulty.
- **Slip Away** (Move or Sneak) from a threat. A Success takes you out of the Clash, and you go on past the obstacle.
- **Shift**, **Patch Up**, or **free a Netted friend** (no roll).

Against a threat, **a Partial does the job, but the threat's Harm hits you**. **A Fail just hits you.**

At the end of each round, each threat that nobody rolled against deals its Harm to one character in the Clash, chosen by the Storyteller.

You can Help a friend's roll in a Clash just as anywhere else: 1 Wild for +1 die, without using your action. Edges work too.

That last rule matters. Leave a Hound alone and it bites someone. Every threat needs somebody rolling against it, even if that's just a Critter Distracting it so the bison can Strike.

How a Clash Ends

THE END OF A CLASH

A Clash ends when every threat is out, when nobody is left in it, or **at the end of round 4**. Then any threats still standing pull back to wait for the Masters.

When a Clash ends, Scent rises once: +1, or +2 if it reached round 4, someone went Down, or someone shifted during it. Anyone who shifted during it is Exposed.

After a Clash, Down and Netted friends get back up if anyone is still standing and the Hunt isn't Up (Chapter 7). If the Clash started at a guarded obstacle, beating the guards (or seeing them pull back) clears it, unless the obstacle still needs progress.

Fighting Smart

- **Shift before the fight, not during it.** If an obstacle is guarded, decide on the way there who's going to be the bison. Shifting mid-Clash costs your action, raises the Clash's Scent to +2, and Exposes you.
- **Pick on one threat at a time.** A Hound with 1 Toughness left is still biting.
- **Small animals Distract.** A mouse can't Strike for much, but a Distract on a Hound's nose makes the big friend's Strike much easier.
- **Get it done in three rounds.** Round 4 costs an extra Scent.
- **Sometimes don't fight at all.** Slip Away is a fine choice when the objective is somewhere else.

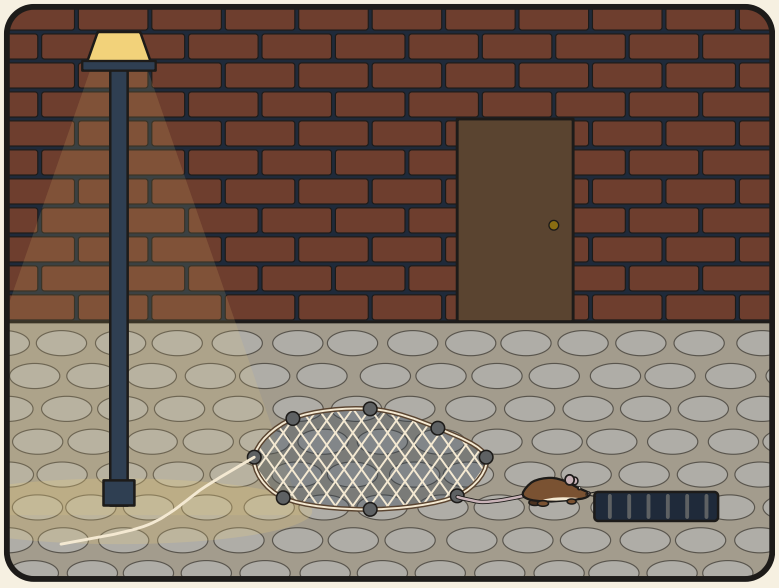
EXAMPLE: TWO HOUNDS ON THE LAWN

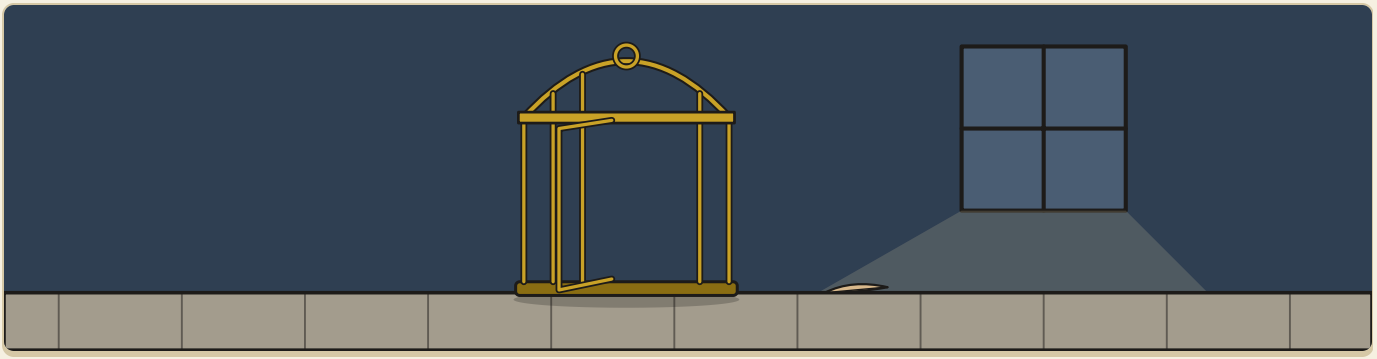
The Hound patrol crosses a dark, open lawn (Open, Dark). Lucía Fails to sneak past, and two Hounds turn: Difficulty 2, Toughness 3, Harm 1. The team was ready: Jonah and Theo shifted on the way in.

Round 1. Priya the barn owl Distracts the first Hound by swooping at its face. She rolls Move: Bird Move 4, +1 die for the Open lawn (a Bird Strength) and +1 die for Silent Wings in the Dark, six dice against Difficulty 2. A Success. Jonah the bison Strikes that Hound: Force 4, +1 die for the Open lawn and +1 for his Football Player perk, against Difficulty 1 thanks to the Distract. A Success: 1 harm. Theo the coyote Strikes the second Hound with four dice (Force 3, +1 for the Open lawn) against Difficulty 2 and gets one hit, a Partial: 1 harm, and the Hound bites back for 1 Hurt. Lucía the alligator Strikes the first Hound with four dice (Force 3, +1 for the Dark, a Reptile Strength): a Success. Both Hounds were rolled against, so neither attacks at the end of the round.

Round 2. The first Hound has 1 Toughness left, the second 2. Jonah Strikes the second and rolls a Critical: 2 harm, and it's out. Lucía Strikes the first and Succeeds: it's out too.

The Clash ends in round 2. Nobody went Down and nobody shifted during it, so it raises Scent by 1. Beating the guards clears the lawn, and as the obstacle ends, Lucía's Fail raises Scent by 1 more.





CHAPTER 7

Hurt, Taken and Worse

Things go wrong. Hounds bite, nets fly, and sometimes a friend doesn't make it out. Nobody in *Second Nature* dies. The worst that happens is being **Taken**, and a Taken friend can always be rescued. Here is everything that can go wrong, from a scraped knee to a cage.

Hurt

HURT

Everyone has **3 Hurt boxes**, the same in every form. Mark one for each point of Hurt you take. **Hurt never lowers your dice:** a bruised kid rolls as well as a fresh one. All Hurt clears between missions.

You take Hurt from a threat's Harm (Chapter 6), from Failing at a dangerous obstacle (Chapter 5), and from shifting with no Wild left (Chapter 4).

PATCH UP

Spend 1 Wild and your action to heal 1 Hurt, yours or a friend's. You can also Patch Up once on the way between obstacles without using an action (instead of shifting).

Down

DOWN

When your third Hurt box is marked, you're **Down**. You can't act until the scene ends.

When the scene ends, if a friend is still standing and the Hunt isn't Up, you get back up with **2 Hurt** and you're past the obstacle: your friends carried you. Otherwise you're **Taken**.

If you go Down in animal form, you're **Stuck**: you can't shift back until the mission ends.

Netted

NETTED

When you Fail against a Trapper, you're **Netted** instead of Hurt. You can't act until a friend spends their action to free you (no roll). When the scene ends, you're freed if a friend is still standing and the Hunt isn't Up; otherwise you're Taken.

Taken

TAKEN

You're **Taken**:

- when you Fail while the Hunt is Up;
- when you're Down or Netted at the end of a scene and nobody is standing to help, or the Hunt is Up.

The Hunt cages you, and you're out for the rest of the mission. If you were carrying the prize, it's lost. You're also Exposed.

A Taken player isn't out of the game. In a one-shot, they can describe what they see from the cage, and it's worth remembering for later. In a campaign, the next mission can be the rescue (Chapter 8).

Exposed

You're **Exposed** when the Hunt sees you shift, or Takes you. They know your face and your Mark now. In a campaign, an Exposed character's next mission starts at Scent 1, because the Hunt is watching your house.

Everyone at Once

If **every** character is Down, Netted or Taken at the same moment, nobody is left to help: everyone is Taken, and the mission is a Loss.

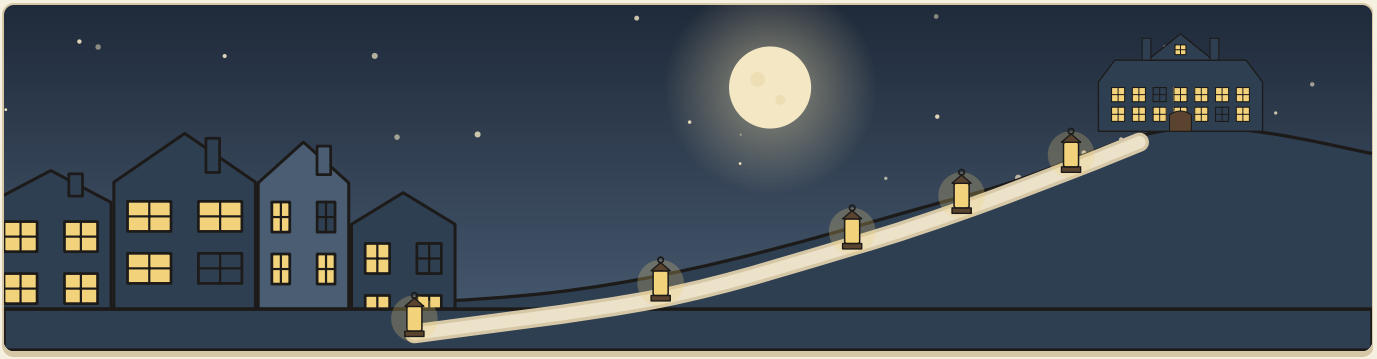
Giving Up

You can always **Withdraw**: abandon the objective and head straight for the Escape (Chapter 5). It's a Loss, but on the way out the only way to be Taken is the usual one: a Fail once the Hunt is Up, or being left Down or Netted. Withdrawing is never better than winning, but it beats being caught.

TELLING IT KINDLY

Describe being Taken the way a good adventure film would: a net drops, a gilded cage clicks shut, and a voice in the dark says, "Well, well. Another one." Keep it tense, never cruel. Being Taken is a cliffhanger, and the rescue is the next chapter.





CHAPTER 8

Campaigns

One mission makes a great evening. A campaign tells the whole story: about six missions against the Gilded Hunt, each one bringing you closer to the night of the Last Hunt, when the Masters will try to chain the Old Wild for good.

The Hunt Track

THE HUNT TRACK

The campaign has one **Hunt track**, from 0 to 6, on the mission tracker. It starts at 0.

- After a **Win**, it doesn't move.
- After a **Costly Win**, it rises by 1.
- After a **Loss**, it rises by 2.

When it reaches **6**, the Last Hunt comes early: the next mission is the Last Hunt. Otherwise the Last Hunt is the seventh mission. The track never goes down.

Growth

GROWTH

After every mission, whatever the result, every character marks **1 Growth**. When you reach 2, 4 and 6 Growth, choose one:

- **+1 Wild:** start every mission with 1 more Wild, to a maximum of 6, counting the Gamer perk.
- **A second human perk.**
- **+1 to a human rating,** to a maximum of 3.
- **Wild Sense:** choose one of your frame's Strengths. It now works in human form too.

You can't choose the same thing twice, except +1 to a human rating (for a different rating each time).

Your Bond grows; your animal doesn't change. You keep one animal for life.

Exposed

If anyone ended a mission Exposed, the Hunt is watching the team. The next mission starts at **Scent 1** (only 1, however many of you were Exposed). After that mission, Exposed clears.

Taken Friends

A Taken character is held by the Hunt. The Hunt means to bind their Bond into a new Trophy on the next full moon, which in a campaign means within the next two missions. Rescuing them can be the team's next mission (*The Lodge on the Hill*, Chapter 17, is written as a rescue), or a Storyteller can add the rescue as an extra objective to another mission.

While a character is Taken, their player makes a new Bonded (or takes a ready-made one) who joins at the **start** of the next mission, never during one. A new character starts with Growth equal to the lowest in the group. When a Taken friend is rescued, their player chooses which of their two characters to play from then on; the other becomes a friend of the team.

If a Taken friend isn't rescued before the full moon, the Hunt makes their Trophy. They lose their Bond and become a normal kid again, but they remember everything. Freeing that Trophy from the Hunt gives them their Bond back; the Storyteller can make that a mission of its own.

Everyone Taken

If the whole team is Taken, play a **Breakout** next: every player makes a new Bonded (or takes a ready-made one), and the new team runs *The Lodge on the Hill* to free the old one.

The Last Hunt

The Last Hunt is the campaign's final mission, on the night the Masters gather to chain the Old Wild. Build it as a Hard mission (Chapter 12) at the place the campaign has been leading to. The higher the Hunt track, the harder it gets: if the Hunt track is 4 or more, lower the mission's Limit by 1. Win it, and the Old Wild stays free, the Trophies break, and every Bonded animal the Hunt ever took runs home. Lose it, and the story isn't over, but the world has become a much tamer place.

DESIGNER'S NOTE

The campaign rules in this chapter haven't been simulated yet; the five missions in Part Three have. Expect Growth, the Hunt track and the Last Hunt to change after playtesting. If something feels off at your table, tell us.

Between Missions

Between missions, you're kids again: school, homework, families who wonder why you're so tired. You don't need rules for this. A few minutes of play between missions, such as spotting a Huntsman at the school gate or hearing a rumour at the shops, is a good way to lead into the next brief.



PART TWO

The Storyteller

How to run the game, who the Gilded Hunt are, the town of Wrenfield, and how to build missions of your own.





CHAPTER 9

Running the Game

As the Storyteller, you are the town, the Hunt, the night, and every voice that isn't a player's. You describe what the Bonded see, smell and hear; you say when a roll is needed and how hard it is; and you play the Hunt fairly but without mercy. You never roll dice. Your job is to set problems; the players' job is to solve them.

The First Night

BEFORE EVERYONE ARRIVES (ABOUT 15 MINUTES)

- **Print** the six ready-made Bonded (Chapter 18) or one blank character sheet per player, one mission tracker, the Storyteller's round card, and the At the Table page (Part Four).
- **Gather** six d6 per player and about six Wild tokens each, plus a marker for the Scent track.
- **Read** *Pemberton's Pets* (Chapter 13), the Easy mission. Note its Limit for your number of players.

AT THE TABLE (ABOUT 15 MINUTES)

1. **Talk about the feel** (two minutes): see "Keeping It Fun" below.
2. **Hand out characters.** Each player takes a ready-made Bonded. If two players want the same one, they roll a die: the higher roll chooses first.
3. **Explain the roll** with one practice roll each: count the 5s and 6s, compare to the Difficulty.
4. **Give everyone 4 Wild** (5 for a Gamer) and explain the four ways to spend it.
5. **Read the brief** and start.

Players don't read the mission pages. Show them the map and the two ways in; tell them an obstacle's approaches and Difficulties when they reach it.

Running an Obstacle

1. **Describe it**, with its tags: "The shop floor is pitch dark. The watchman is asleep by the counter."
2. **Say what works:** "Sneak or Move, Difficulty 2. It's a group obstacle: everyone has to get past."
3. **Ask who does what.** Let the players decide forms, who rolls and who Helps.
4. **Resolve the rolls**: result first, then its cost.
5. **Mark Scent** as the rules say, and describe the change: a dog barks two streets away; a light comes on upstairs.

If a player wants to try something that isn't on the obstacle's list, pick the nearest approach and Difficulty from the list. Don't make up a new approach that skips the obstacle: every way through is a roll.

Running a Clash

Use the round card in Part Four. It has four steps:

A CLASH ROUND

1. Everyone in the Clash takes one action, in any order the players like. Help can come at any time.
2. Resolve each roll as it's made: result, then Harm.
3. Each threat nobody rolled against this round hurts one character of your choice.
4. Check the end: every threat out, nobody left, or the end of round 4. Then raise Scent once: +1, or +2 if it reached round 4, someone went Down, or someone shifted during it.

When a threat attacks someone, choose fairly. Pick whoever the threat would really go for, such as the one who just hit it or the one closest to it, rather than always the weakest.

The Scent Track

Keep the Scent track where everyone can see it. The Hunt closing in should be a shared, growing dread, not a secret. When Scent reaches half the Limit, tell the players: "They're On the Trail. The way out will be harder." When it reaches the Limit, make it big: horns, lights, the baying of Hounds. The Hunt is Up.

Making Rulings

The rules don't cover everything. When something comes up:

- **Choose the reading nearest to what the rules already say,** and say it out loud so everyone knows.
- **Never make a roll free.** No plan, perk or trick lets anyone skip an obstacle without a roll.
- **Write it down** and keep that ruling for the rest of the campaign. We'd love to hear about it too.

Keeping It Fun

This game is for ages 10 and up. Some players will want the Hunt to be properly scary; others won't. Before the first mission, ask:

- **Is there anything nobody wants in the game?** Snakes, spiders, cages, the dark. Take it out or keep it off-screen.
- **How scary should the Hunt be?** Creepy-and-cold, or bluster-and-moustache?

During play, anyone can say **"pause"** at any time, for any reason, and the game stops while you talk. Then carry on, change direction, or skip ahead. Nobody has to explain why.

Keep the violence light. Hits are scrapes and bruises; a threat that's "out" is knocked over, chased off or tangled in its own net. Nobody bleeds and nobody dies.

Giving Every Animal Its Moment

Look at the team's frames before a mission, and notice the tags. A mission with no Water gives an alligator little to do; one with no Narrow gaps leaves a mouse on the bench. The missions in this book spread their tags so that every frame has a place to shine. When you build your own (Chapter 12), do the same.

Pacing

- **One roll at a time at a point obstacle.** If someone fancies a turn, let them have the next round.
- **Move quickly between obstacles.** A sentence of description, then the next problem.
- **Remind players to spend Wild.** Every token left at the end is wasted.
- **A mission takes two to three hours.** If you're running long, it's fine to describe the last stretch of the Escape after its final roll.





CHAPTER 10

The Gilded Hunt

"Every wild thing has a price. Most of them simply haven't been asked yet." — overheard at the Lodge on Thornhill

The Gilded Hunt is older than the town, older than the roads, older than anyone's great-grandmother's stories. It began as a club of rich hunters who found out, long ago, that a Bonded animal caught alive and bound in gold gives up its gift to whoever wears the gold. They have been collecting ever since.

What the Hunt Wants

The Hunt wants the Wild itself. Every Trophy they make is a little piece of it, chained. For three hundred years they have been preparing for the **Last Hunt**: one night, under the right moon, when the Masters gather and bind the Old Wild for good. After that, every animal on Earth would obey whoever holds the leash, and the Hunt means to hold it. The people would follow soon after.

The Old Wild knows. That's why it woke the Bonded.

Who They Are

Members of the Hunt are respectable. They sit on the museum board, own the mill, sponsor the zoo, give prizes at the school sports day. They are polite, generous and charming, and they never, ever talk about the Hunt in daylight. Nobody joins by accident. You're invited, you're tested, and you swear.

- **Masters** lead the Hunt. Each wears several Trophies. They rarely leave the Lodge, and when they do, it's because the Hunt is Up.
- **Huntsmen** are full members. Each has earned one Trophy.
- **Beaters** are hired hands: watchmen, drivers, "estate staff". Most of them don't know what the Hunt really is, and don't want to.
- **Trappers** are the Hunt's specialists in catching things alive, with nets and cages.
- **Hounds** are the Hunt's own breed: tall, grey and silent, with gilt collars and noses that can smell the Wild.

Trophies

A **Trophy** is a Bonded animal's gift, bound into a piece of gold: a ring, a brooch, a cane-head, a locket. Whoever wears it borrows that animal's best sense or strength. Every Trophy was once somebody's Bond. Break one, and the Bond goes free.

TROPHY	WHAT IT LENDS
Hawkseye Ring	Eyes that see a mouse move at the far end of a field.
Wolfnose Brooch	A nose that can follow yesterday's footsteps.
Owl's-Ear Earrings	Hearing that catches a whisper through a wall.
Bearpaw Cane	Strength to lift a car door off its hinges.
Stag-Heart Locket	Legs that never tire.
Snakeskin Gloves	Hands that sense warmth in the dark.

In play, a Huntsman's Trophy makes them hard to sneak past (below). What it looks like and what it lends is up to you.

How the Hunt Finds You

The Hunt can smell the Wild. When the Bonded slip up, make noise, fight or shift in sight, the Hunt's **Scent** grows (Chapter 5). The Hounds track it; the Trophies sharpen it; and when it's strong enough, the Masters come. Between missions the Hunt is patient: it watches Exposed children, asks friendly questions at the school gate, and waits.

What the Hunt Does With the Taken

The Taken are caged, gently and coldly, like prize animals. The Hunt doesn't hurt them; it needs them whole. At the next full moon, a Master binds the Taken child's Bond into new gold. Until then, they can be rescued.

The Threats

Every threat has a Difficulty, a Toughness and a Harm (Chapter 6). They never roll.

Beater

"I'm just the night man, kid."



DIFFICULTY 2 **TOUGHNESS** 2 **HARM** 1

Special: None.

Hired muscle in a flat cap and a warm coat. Beaters guard doors, drive vans and walk the grounds with a torch. They'd rather shout than chase.

Hound

grey, silent, gilt-collared



DIFFICULTY 2 **TOUGHNESS** 3 **HARM** 1

Tracker: Sneak rolls at an obstacle a Hound guards are at +1 Difficulty.

Long-legged, grey and unnervingly quiet. Hounds never bark; they just look at you. They can smell the Wild on a Bonded kid even in human form.

Trapper

"Hold still. This won't hurt."



DIFFICULTY 2 **TOUGHNESS** 2 **HARM** 1

Net: When you Fail against a Trapper, you're Netted instead of Hurt (Chapter 7).

Patient people in waxed jackets with weighted nets and folding cages. Trappers catch things alive. That's the point.

Huntsman
a member, wearing a Trophy



DIFFICULTY 3 **TOUGHNESS** 4 **HARM** 2

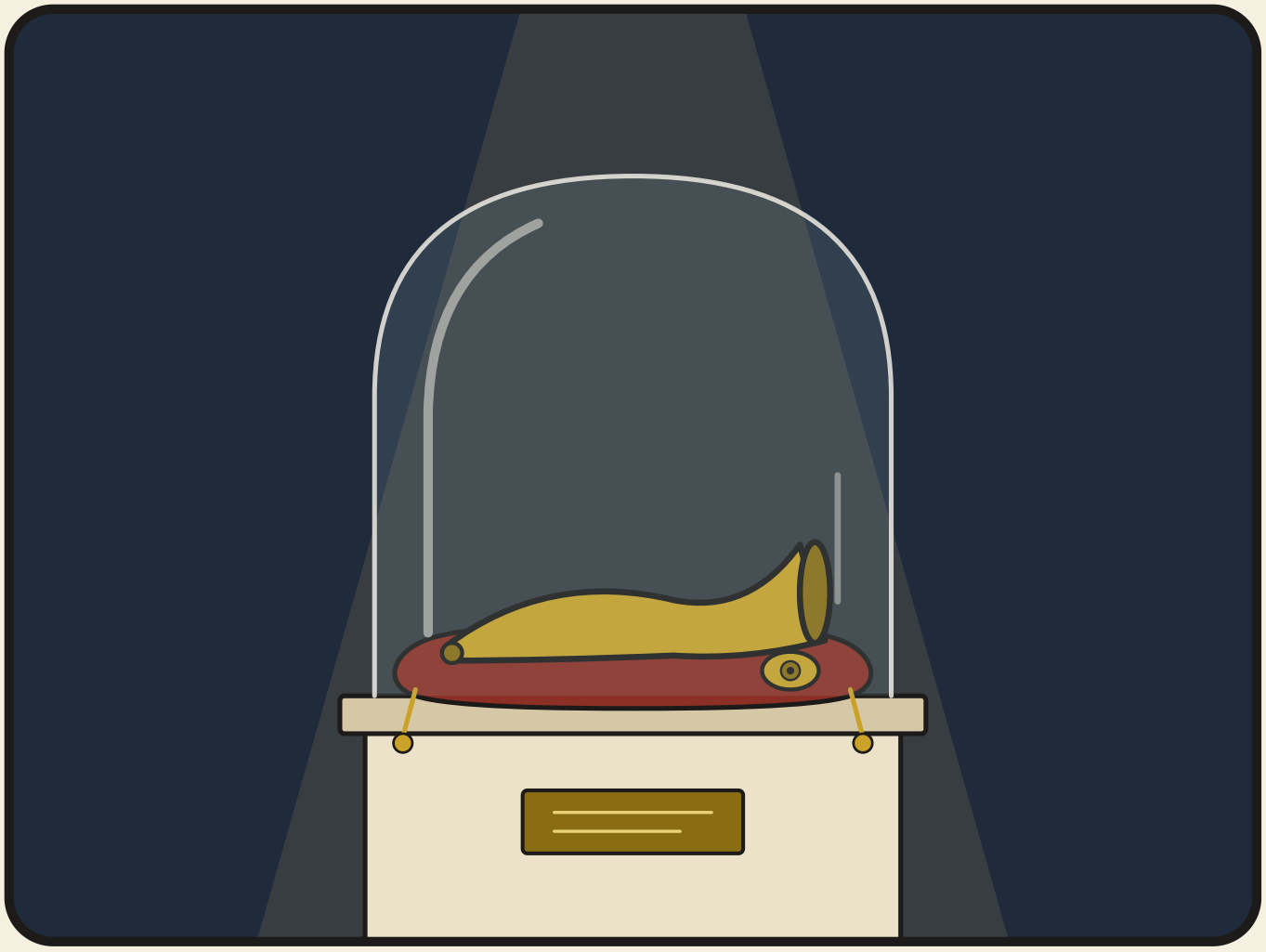
Trophy: Sneak rolls at an obstacle a Huntsman guards are at +1 Difficulty.

A full member of the Hunt, in good tweed and a gold Trophy. Huntsmen are clever, calm and very hard to fool. They don't chase you. They wait for you to make a mistake.

Master of the Hunt
"Well, well. Another one."

Arrives: Only when the Hunt is Up (Chapter 5). Masters are never fought. While they're here, any Fail means you're Taken.

The leaders of the Hunt, hung with Trophies, moving through the dark with a dozen borrowed senses. When a Master arrives, the only sensible thing to do is run.

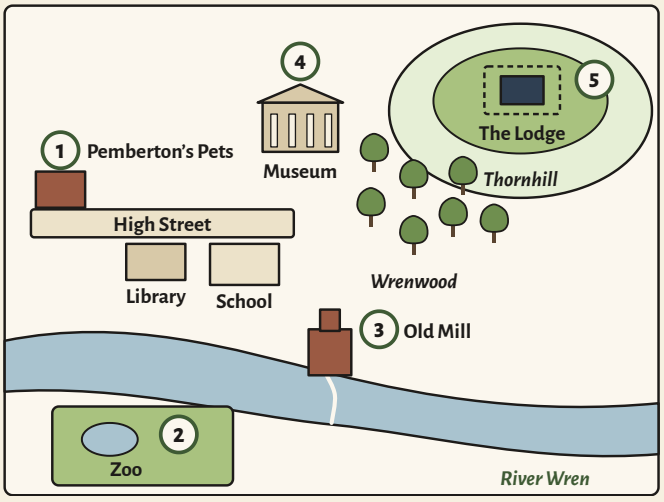




CHAPTER 11

Wrenfield

WRENFIELD IS A SMALL RIVER TOWN WITH ONE high street, one cinema, two schools and a hill nobody climbs. You can play in your own town instead (it's more fun when you know the streets), but Wrenfield is where the missions in this book take place, and it's ready to use.



Wrenfield. The five missions in Part Three take place at the numbered places.

The Night of the Waking

Last October a storm knocked out every light in Wrenfield for one hour. In that hour the zoo's fences failed, animals got loose all over town, and six children each found themselves face to face with one of them. By morning the animals were back in their pens or gone into the woods, and the children were Bonded. Most people remember it as "the night the zoo got out". The Hunt remembers it very differently.

Places

1. PEMBERTON'S PETS

A cramped old pet shop at the end of the High Street. Old Mrs Pemberton ran it for forty years and sold it last spring to a polite company nobody had heard of. The new manager, **Mr Rook**, keeps odd hours, and the strays of Wrenfield have started to disappear. *Mission: Chapter 13.*

2. WRENFIELD ZOO

A small, much-loved zoo by the river, with a moat, an aviary and a famous pair of snow leopards. Since the night of the Waking, its director, **Dr Imogen Hale**, has hired new "transport staff" who work only at night. *Mission: Chapter 14.*

3. THE OLD MILL

A tall brick mill on the River Wren, with a working waterwheel the town keeps for show. Its owner, **Mr Corwin Thatch**, has been building something in the tower. The Hounds have been restless ever since. *Mission: Chapter 15.*

4. THE ASHCOMBE MUSEUM

Wrenfield's natural history museum: dark halls of stuffed animals, a dinosaur skeleton, and a glass case of "historic hunting jewellery" that is never quite the same twice. Once a year it hosts a grand gala for its patrons. *Mission: Chapter 16.*

5. THE LODGE ON THORNHILL

A great stone house on the wooded hill above the town, behind a deer park and a high wall. It belongs to **Lady Cordelia Vane**, Master of the Hunt in Wrenfield, though in town she's known only as a generous patron of the museum and the zoo. *Mission: Chapter 17.*

ELSEWHERE IN TOWN

- **The High Street:** the chip shop, the bakery, the cinema, and the bus stop where everyone meets.
- **Wrenfield Library:** warm, quiet, and full of old maps. The librarian, **Ms Dara Quill**, has been reading about the Hunt for years and is the closest thing the Bonded have to an adult ally.
- **Wrenwood:** the woods between the town and Thornhill, full of badgers, owls and old paths. A good place to shift unseen.
- **The River Wren:** slow and brown, with a towpath, a weir by the mill, and drains that run under half the town.
- **Wrenfield Middle School:** where most of the Bonded spend their days, trying to stay awake.

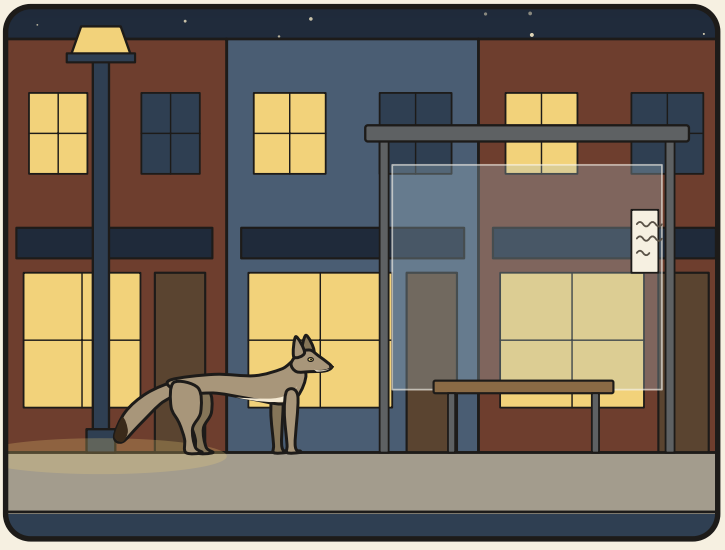
People

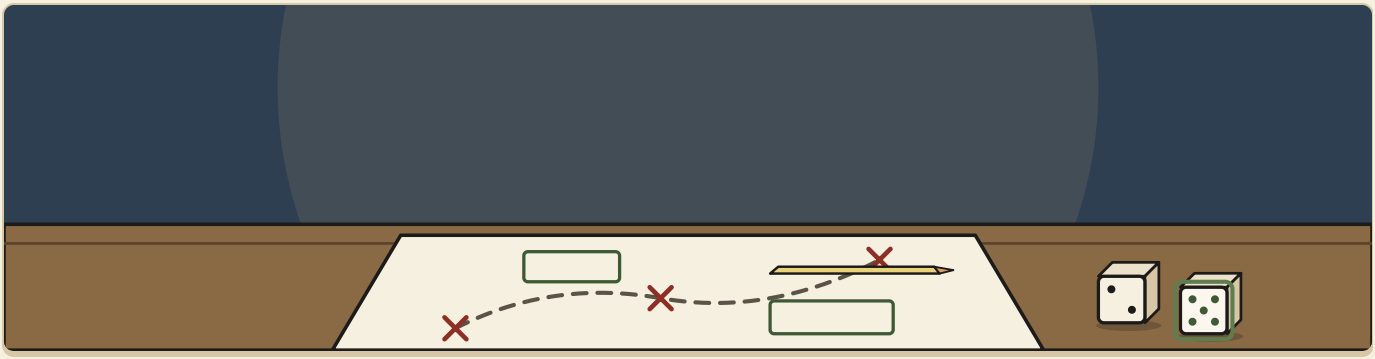
WHO	WHAT THEY SEEM	WHAT THEY ARE
Lady Cordelia Vane	Kind, wealthy patron of the arts	Master of the Hunt
Mr Rook	Mild new manager of Pemberton's Pets	Huntsman (Hawkseye Ring)
Dr Imogen Hale	Brisk, busy zoo director	Huntsman (Wolfnose Brooch)
Mr Corwin Thatch	Jolly mill owner and town councillor	Huntsman (Bearpaw Cane)
Ms Dara Quill	Quiet librarian	An ally who knows the Hunt's history
Mrs Pemberton	Retired shopkeeper	Sold her shop to the Hunt without knowing, and regrets it

Rumours

Between missions, roll a d6 or choose one to lead into the next brief.

D6	RUMOUR
1	"Have you seen the posters? Half the cats on Mill Lane are missing." (Pemberton's Pets)
2	"My cousin works at the zoo. She says the new night staff drive the vans out with the lights off." (The Zoo After Dark)
3	"Something in the mill tower hums at night. Every dog in town howls when it does." (The Old Mill)
4	"The museum gala's on Saturday. They say there's a new piece in the jewellery case." (The Trophy Gala)
5	"Nobody's seen that new kid since Tuesday. Someone said a big grey dog followed him home." (The Lodge on the Hill)
6	"Ms Quill wants to see you at the library. She says it's about the storm." (any mission)





CHAPTER 12

Making Missions

Once you've played the missions in Part Three, you'll want your own: the Hunt at the swimming baths, the Hunt at the school fair, the Hunt in your actual town. This chapter shows how to build one that plays well. The shape is always the same: two ways in, a few obstacles, an objective, and a way out.

The Checklist

EVERY MISSION HAS

- **A brief:** what the Hunt is doing and what the team must do: free, wreck or steal.
- **A map** that matches the obstacles, place by place.
- **Two ways in,** each a different kind of obstacle, so scouting matters.
- **Two to four obstacles inside,** then the **objective**.
- **One or two Escape obstacles,** each with at least two approaches, so no team is stuck without a way out.
- **For every obstacle:** its tags, every approach that works and its Difficulty, point or group, the progress needed, and any guards or danger.
- **Stats for every threat** (use Chapter 10).
- **A Limit for 3, 4 and 5 players,** and a label (Easy, Standard or Hard).
- **At least one moment for human form:** someone to talk past, a lock to work, a crowd to blend into.

Choosing Obstacles

Give most obstacles two or three approaches, so different animals can solve them in different ways. A wall might be Move 2 (climb or fly it), Sneak 3 (find the gap) or Force 3 (break through). Then give it tags, and think about who they favour:

TAG	STRONG HERE	WEAK HERE
Dark	Big Cats, Reptiles	—
High	Big Cats, Birds	Canines
Narrow	Critters	Birds, Heavies
Water	Reptiles	Big Cats
Open	Canines, Birds, Heavies	Critters
Crowd	Canines, Critters	Big Cats, Heavies, Reptiles
Locked	Heavies	—

Across a mission, try to use every tag at least once, and don't let one tag take over. A mission that is all rooftops is a mission for birds.

DIFFICULTY

- **1:** routine, for a quick roll that rarely goes wrong.
- **2:** the normal Difficulty for anything worth rolling.
- **3:** hard, the approach that works but isn't the obvious one.
- **4:** almost never on its own; Weaknesses and Trackers will push some rolls there anyway.

POINT OR GROUP?

If one person could deal with it for everyone (open a door, find the path), make it a **point** obstacle needing 1 to 3 progress. If everyone has to get past it themselves (cross a yard, climb a wall), make it a **group** obstacle. Group obstacles are harder with more players, point obstacles easier; that's what the per-size Limit is for.

GUARDS AND DANGER

Guard one or two obstacles per mission: a Beater at the door, two Hounds on the lawn, a Huntsman at the objective. A **dangerous** obstacle (a fast river, a high beam) deals 1 Hurt on a Fail. Use it where a fall or a current makes sense.

Setting the Limit

The Limit is what makes a mission Easy or Hard. The five missions in Part Three were tested thousands of times, with groups of 3, 4 and 5, so their Limits hit their labels. For a new mission:

1. **Find the most similar mission in Part Three**: same number of obstacles, similar Difficulties, similar guards. Start from its Limits.
2. **For each extra obstacle** you add, add 1 to each Limit. For each one fewer, take 1 away.
3. **Play it, and adjust.** If the Hunt is Up in nearly every game, add 1; if it's never Up, take 1 away.

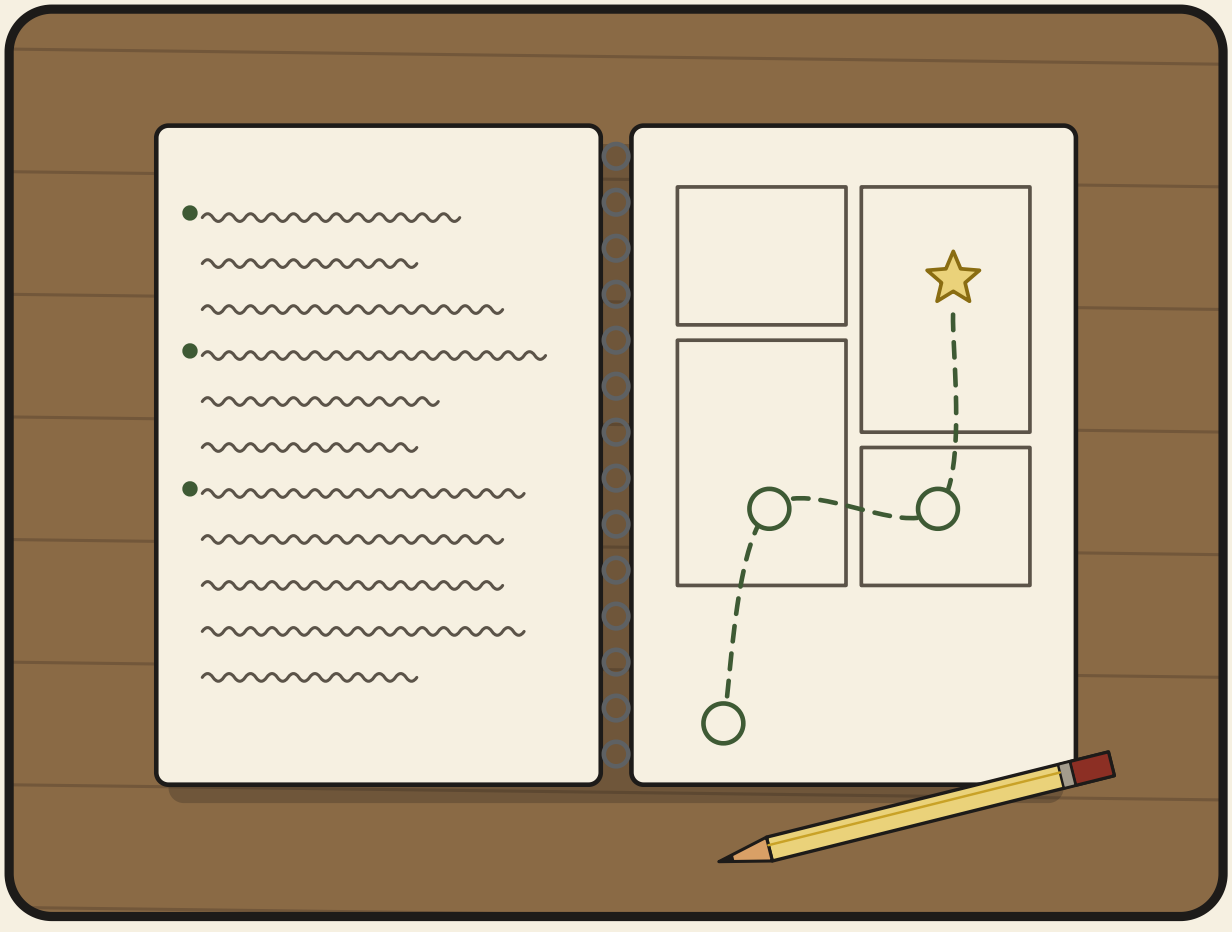
DESIGNER'S NOTE

Steps 2 and 3 are a rule of thumb, not something we've tested. A mission's label should come from how it actually plays, not from what you meant it to be. If your Easy mission keeps going wrong, it's a Standard mission, and that's fine.

Ideas

D6	THE HUNT IS…	AT…
1	caging animals for bait	the swimming baths after closing
2	stealing a Bonded kid's family pet to lure them out	the school fair
3	moving Trophies in a van	the multi-storey car park
4	training new Hounds	the old quarry
5	holding a secret meeting	the golf club
6	building another Callhorn	the church tower

These are starting points, not finished missions: each still needs its obstacles, map and Limits.

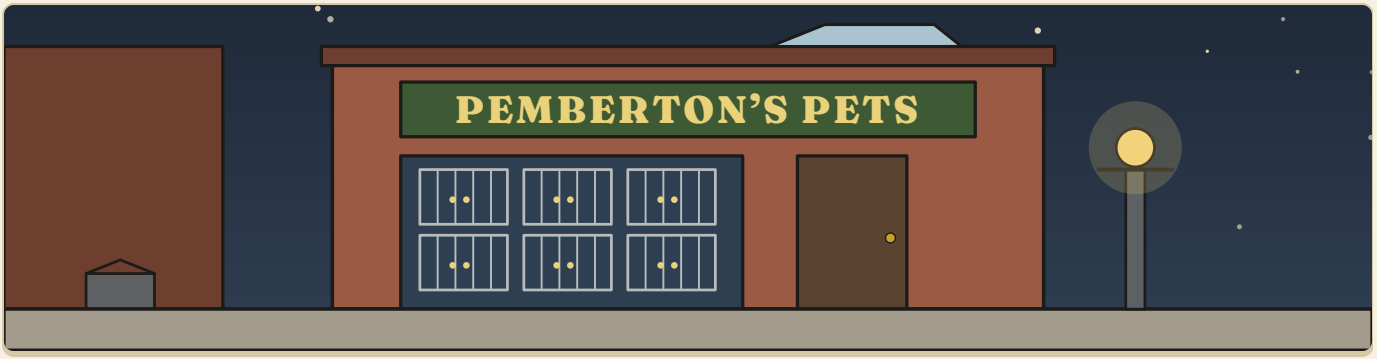


PART THREE

Missions

Five ready-to-play missions against the Hunt, from an easy first night to the Lodge itself.

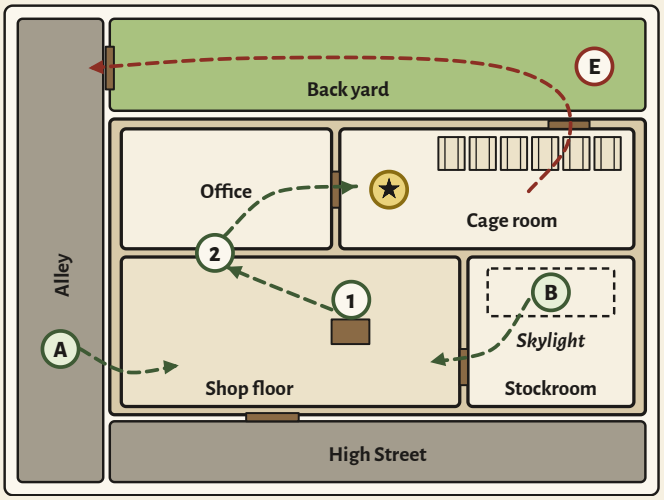




CHAPTER 13 · EASY MISSION

Pemberton's Pets

The first mission, made for a first night. The Hunt has bought the old pet shop on the High Street and is caging the town's strays: bait, to draw out the Bonded. The team gets in after closing, past a sleepy watchman, and opens every cage.



Pemberton's Pets. On every mission map, A and B are the ways in, the numbers are the obstacles inside, ★ is the objective and E is the Escape, just as in the table below.

READ THIS ALOUD

The posters are everywhere: lost cats, lost dogs, lost rabbits. Tonight you found out where they went. Through the back window of Pemberton's Pets you saw them, dozens of them, in a back room stacked high with cages. The shop shut at six. The watchman came at eight. The new manager, Mr Rook, will collect the animals in the morning. You have tonight.

What's Going On

Mr Rook is a Huntsman. He's gathering strays because the Hunt has learned that Bonded children can't resist rescuing animals, and tomorrow the cages go up to the Lodge. Tonight only one Beater is on watch, asleep in a chair on the shop floor. Mr Rook lives above the shop and will come down if the Hunt is Up.

WHERE	OBSTACLE	TAGS	APPROACHES (DIFFICULTY)	KIND · PROGRESS	NOTES
Way in A	**The coal chute**	Dark, Narrow	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	—
Way in B	**The skylight**	High, Locked	Force 3 · Move 2 · Wits 2	Point · 2	—
Inside 1	**The shop floor (night watchman)**	Dark	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	Guarded by a Beater. Beating it clears it.
Inside 2	**The office door**	Locked	Force 3 · Wits 2	Point · 2	—
Objective	**The cages**	Locked, Narrow	Force 3 · Wits 2	Point · 3	—
Escape	**Out the back**	Dark, Open	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	—

Scent Limit: 7 with 3 players · 6 with 4 · 5 with 5. **Scouting:** Sense, Difficulty 2.

The Places

WAY IN A: THE COAL CHUTE

An old iron hatch in the alley opens onto a coal chute down into the cellar, then up a short stair into the shop. It's black as pitch and just wide enough for a kid. Cats and Critters will love it.

WAY IN B: THE SKYLIGHT

On the flat roof, reached by the drainpipe or by wing, a skylight is latched from the inside. One of you climbs up and works the latch open (or forces it); then everyone drops into the stockroom below.

INSIDE 1: THE SHOP FLOOR

Aisles of pet food and fish tanks, all dark. The watchman snores in a chair by the till. Everyone has to get past him to the office. If anyone Fails, he wakes, and it's a Clash.

INSIDE 2: THE OFFICE DOOR

The door to the back is locked. The key hangs on a hook on the watchman's belt, which is no help, but the lock is old: a human hand can work it with a hairpin, or something heavy can break it.

THE OBJECTIVE: THE CAGE ROOM

Floor-to-ceiling cages: cats, dogs, rabbits, a tortoise, two very angry geese. The room is crowded and narrow. Every latch has to be opened, or every door broken. When the last cage opens, the animals pour out of the back door ahead of you.

THE ESCAPE: OUT THE BACK

The back yard, a gate and the alley, dark and open. Everyone has to get clear before Mr Rook reaches the window.

Threats

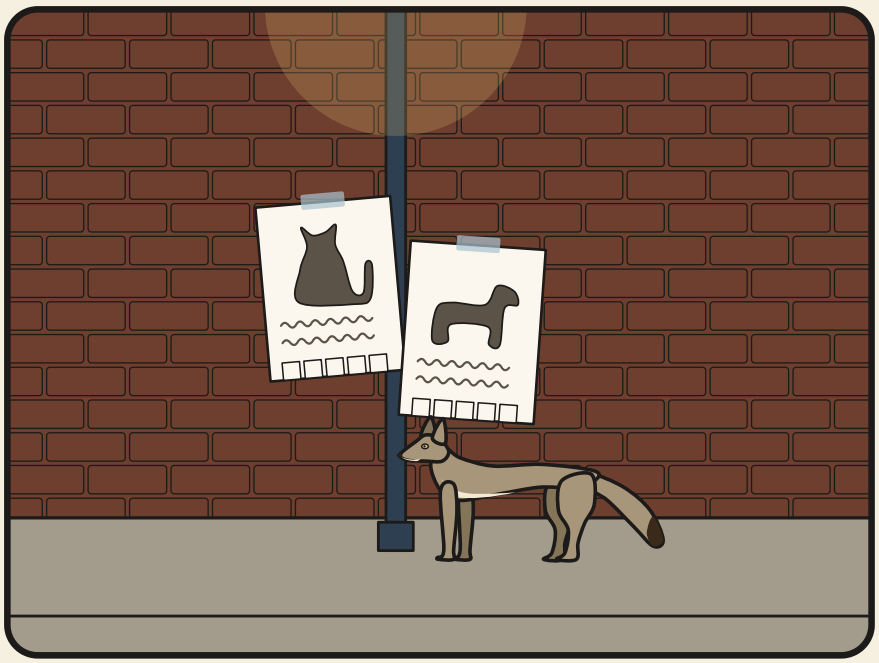
The watchman is a Beater (Chapter 10). If the Hunt is Up, Mr Rook comes downstairs with a Master's car already turning into the High Street. Nobody fights them: it's time to run.

RUNNING IT ON A FIRST NIGHT

Let the players see the whole map. Point out the chute and the skylight and let them argue about which to pick before they scout. At the shop floor, remind them that a Fail wakes the watchman. At the office door and the cages, ask who's staying human: these are the obstacles that need hands.

After the Mission

- **Win:** the strays scatter across Wrenfield, and the posters come down one by one. Mr Rook knows somebody was here.
- **Costly Win:** the strays are free, but a friend was caught. They're taken to the Lodge on Thornhill: the rescue can be *The Lodge on the Hill*.
- **Loss:** in the morning a grey van takes the cages up the hill. The Hunt track rises.

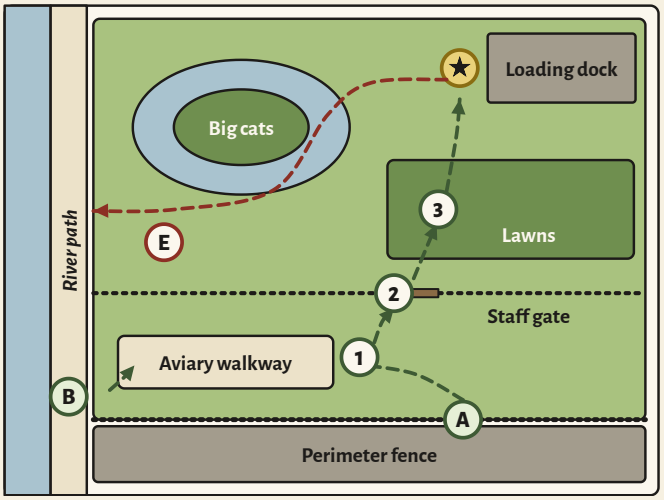




CHAPTER 14 · STANDARD MISSION

The Zoo After Dark

The Hunt's Trappers are crating the zoo's animals at night and driving them to the Lodge. Tonight it's the snow leopards. The team gets into the zoo, finds the Trappers, slips past the Hound patrol and breaks open the crates before the truck leaves.



Wrenfield Zoo, by the river.

READ THIS ALOUD

The zoo has been closed for an hour. From the river path you can hear engines where there shouldn't be any: a truck with its lights off, backing up to the loading dock. A woman in a waxed jacket is checking a clipboard. On the side of a crate, in fresh chalk: SNOW LEOPARD ×2 — THORNHILL. You have until they finish loading.

What's Going On

Dr Hale, the zoo's director, is a Huntsman. She's been quietly sending the zoo's animals up to the Lodge, where the Hunt uses them to train its Hounds and to tempt the Bonded. Two Trappers are loading tonight's crates. A pair of Hounds patrol the grounds, and an ordinary night keeper (who knows nothing about the Hunt) is on the staff gate.

WHERE	OBSTACLE	TAGS	APPROACHES (DIFFICULTY)	KIND · PROGRESS	NOTES
Way in A	**The perimeter fence**	Open, High	Sneak 3 · Move 2	Group	—
Way in B	**The river culvert**	Water, Narrow, Dark	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	Dangerous: a Fail deals 1 Hurt.
Inside 1	**Find the Trappers**	High, Open, Dark	Sense 2	Point · 2	—
Inside 2	**The night keeper at the staff gate**	—	Sneak 3 · Wits 2	Group	—
Inside 3	**The Hound patrol**	Open, Dark	Sneak 2 · Move 2 · Sense 3	Group	Guarded by 2 Hounds. Beating them clears it.
Objective	**The crates on the loading dock**	Locked	Force 3 · Wits 2	Point · 3	Guarded by 2 Trappers. Clash first, then progress.
Escape	**Across the moat**	Water, Open	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	—

Scent Limit: 8 with 3 players · 8 with 4 · 8 with 5. **Scouting:** Sense, Difficulty 2.

The Places

WAY IN A: THE PERIMETER FENCE

A tall wire fence along the open car park. It's easy to climb or fly, but anyone sneaking along it is in plain view of the road.

WAY IN B: THE RIVER CULVERT

A drain runs under the fence from the river, dark and half full of cold water. The current is strong: a Fail here deals 1 Hurt.

INSIDE 1: FIND THE TRAPPERS

The zoo is big and dark. From the aviary walkway, high above the paths, you can watch for torches and listen for the truck. It takes a sharp pair of eyes, or a good nose.

INSIDE 2: THE NIGHT KEEPER

Old Mr Dunmore on the staff gate is no Huntsman, just a tired man with a flask of tea. A kid with a good story ("My mum's a volunteer and I left my bag in the café") can talk their way past. Sneaking past is harder; he has nothing else to look at. An animal can't talk, so it's Sneak or nothing for them.

INSIDE 3: THE HOUND PATROL

Two Hounds walk the lawns between the staff gate and the loading dock. Everyone has to cross. Anyone who watches the patrol long enough can find the gap in it (Sense 3). If anyone Fails, the Hounds turn, and it's a Clash.

THE OBJECTIVE: THE LOADING DOCK

Six crates on the dock, two of them already in the truck, and two Trappers working by lamplight. The crates are locked with padlocks and bolts: open them with clever hands or break them. If you Fail while the Trappers are there, they come at you with nets. Beating them doesn't open the crates: you still need 3 progress. When the last crate opens, the snow leopards bound away into the dark.

THE ESCAPE: ACROSS THE MOAT

The fastest way out is across the old moat around the big cat enclosure and up onto the river path. It's cold, wet and wide open.

Threats

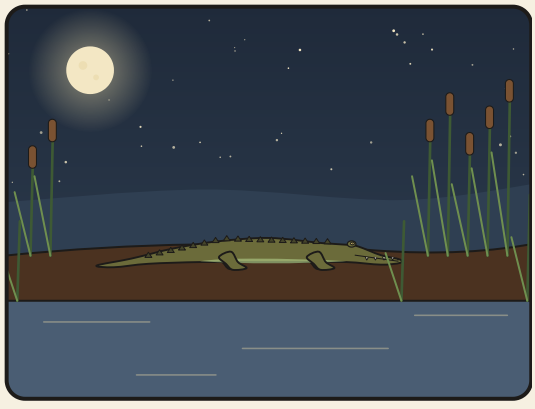
Two Hounds on the patrol and **two Trappers** at the dock (Chapter 10). The night keeper isn't a threat; if he sees an animal he just phones the zoo vet. If the Hunt is Up, Dr Hale arrives with a Master, and the truck's headlights snap on.

SPOTLIGHTS

Birds and Canines shine finding the Trappers. A Reptile is at home in the culvert and the moat. The staff gate needs someone in human form who can talk. Big Cats hate the moat; let them find another way, or swim it as a kid.

After the Mission

- **Win:** the snow leopards are back in their enclosure by morning, and the truck leaves empty. Dr Hale starts checking who's been visiting the zoo.
- **Costly Win:** the leopards are free, but a friend went up the hill in a crate instead.
- **Loss:** the truck leaves for Thornhill. The Hunt now has two more animals to train its Hounds with.

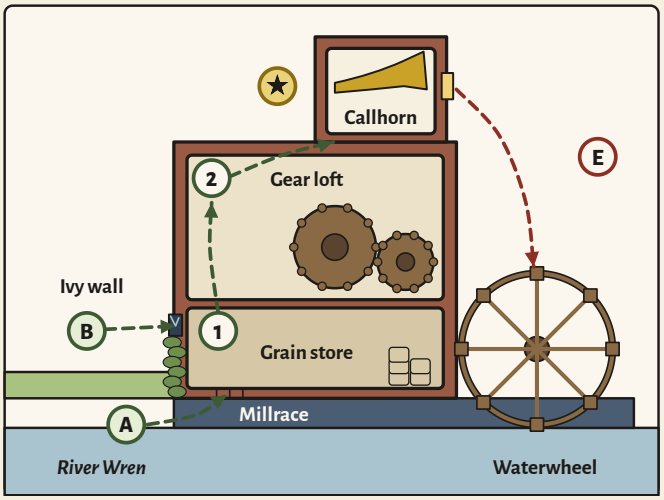




CHAPTER 15 · STANDARD MISSION

The Old Mill

Mr Thatch has built a Callhorn in the tower of the Old Mill: a great brass horn that, when it sounds, sends every Hound in Wrenfield out hunting at once. The team gets into the mill, climbs through the gears to the top of the tower and wrecks the Callhorn before it's finished.



The Old Mill, cut away to show its floors.

READ THIS ALOUD

Every night this week, at midnight, the whole town's dogs have howled at once. Tonight you followed the sound to the Old Mill. Up in the tower window there's a glint of brass, and the low hum of something waking up. Down below, the waterwheel turns in the dark. Whatever that thing is, it's nearly ready.

What's Going On

The Callhorn is nearly finished. Once it works, the Hunt can loose every Hound in town at once, on any night it likes. Mr Thatch is in the tower, fitting the last pieces. A Beater and a Hound guard the grain store on the ground floor.

WHERE	OBSTACLE	TAGS	APPROACHES (DIFFICULTY)	KIND · PROGRESS	NOTES
Way in A	**The millrace**	Water, Dark	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	Dangerous: a Fail deals 1 Hurt.
Way in B	**The ivy wall**	High	Sneak 3 · Move 2	Group	—
Inside 1	**The grain store (a Beater and a Hound)**	Dark, Narrow	Sneak 2 · Move 3 · Sense 3 · Wits 2	Group	Guarded by a Beater and a Hound. Beating them clears it.
Inside 2	**The gear loft**	High, Narrow	Move 2 · Sense 3	Point · 3	Dangerous: a Fail deals 1 Hurt.
Objective	**The Callhorn**	High, Locked	Force 3 · Wits 2	Point · 3	Guarded by a Huntsman. Clash first, then progress.
Escape	**Down the waterwheel**	Water, High	Sneak 3 · Move 2	Group	—

Scent Limit: 7 with 3 players · 7 with 4 · 6 with 5. **Scouting:** Sense, Difficulty 2.

The Places

WAY IN A: THE MILLRACE

The fast channel of water that turns the wheel runs right under the mill, and through a grating into the cellar. It's dark and fast: a Fail deals 1 Hurt.

WAY IN B: THE IVY WALL

The back wall of the mill is covered in ancient ivy, up to a broken window high in the wall of the grain store. It's an easy climb for anything with claws or wings, and an awkward one for a kid.

INSIDE 1: THE GRAIN STORE

A dark, cramped room of sacks and bins, with a Beater and a Hound on guard. Everyone has to get past. A kid in human form can try the oldest trick ("Dad sent me to fetch Mr Thatch"), or you can sneak, or squeeze along the top of the bins. If anyone Fails, it's a Clash.

INSIDE 2: THE GEAR LOFT

Huge wooden gears turn in the dark, and the only way up is through them: along beams, between teeth, up a narrow ladder. One of you finds the path and calls the others through. A Fail here deals 1 Hurt.

THE OBJECTIVE: THE CALLHORN

At the top of the tower, a brass horn as long as a bus, bolted into the beams, with Mr Thatch working beside it. It can be smashed, if you're very strong, or taken apart by clever hands, bolt by bolt. If anyone Fails while Mr Thatch is there, it's a Clash; beating him doesn't wreck the horn.

THE ESCAPE: DOWN THE WATERWHEEL

The quickest way out of the tower is the window above the waterwheel, then down its turning paddles into the river.

Threats

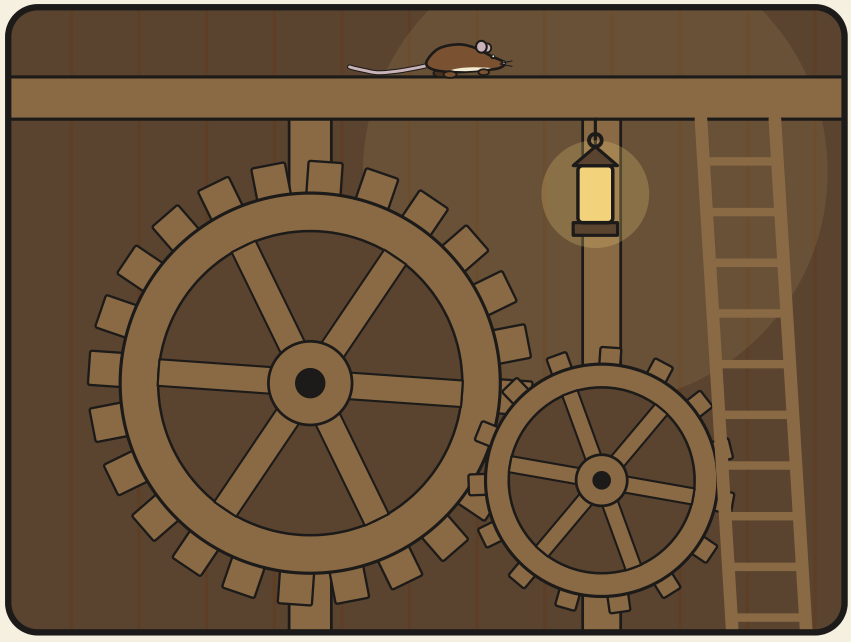
A **Beater** and a **Hound** in the grain store, and **Mr Thatch**, a Huntsman with a Bearpaw Cane, at the Callhorn (Chapter 10). If the Hunt is Up, the Masters come up the stairs, and the Callhorn gives a long, terrible groan.

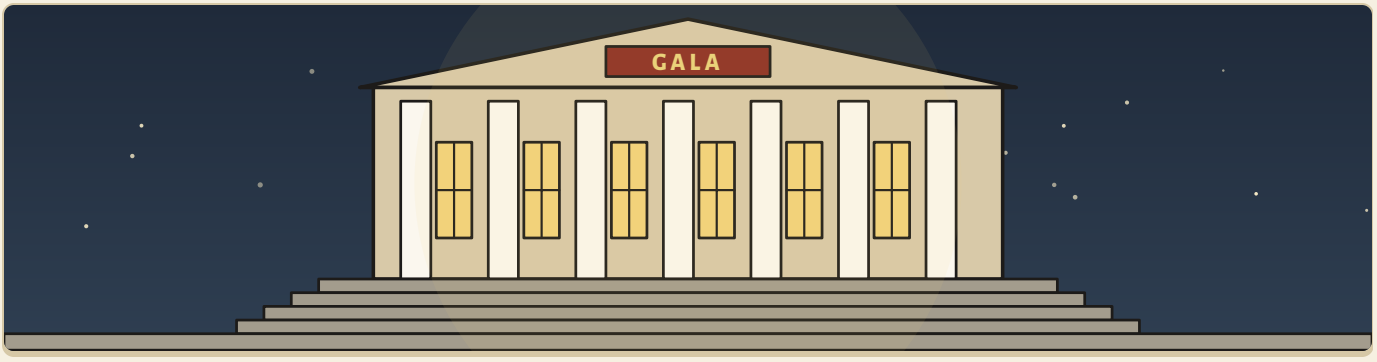
SPOTLIGHTS

Reptiles love the millrace and the wheel; Big Cats, Birds and Critters love the ivy and the gear loft. The Callhorn is a job for a Heavy or for clever hands, and Mr Thatch is a fight for the whole team.

After the Mission

- **Win:** the Callhorn falls in pieces, and Wrenfield's dogs sleep soundly again. Mr Thatch limps home and doesn't say a word about it at the council meeting.
- **Costly Win:** the horn is wrecked, but a friend was caught in the tower.
- **Loss:** the Callhorn is finished. On the next mission, the Hunt can loose its Hounds whenever it likes: the Storyteller may add a Hound to one guarded obstacle.

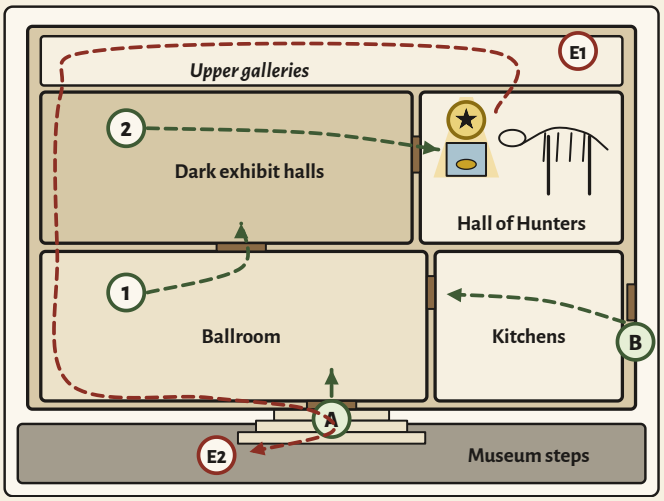




CHAPTER 16 · HARD MISSION

The Trophy Gala

Once a year the Ashcombe Museum throws a gala for its patrons, and this year the Hunt is showing off its newest Trophy: a silver pendant holding the Bond of a girl from the next town, whose animal was an otter. The team gets into a crowded party, through the dark halls where the Hounds wait, steals the pendant from its guarded case and carries it out.



The Ashcombe Museum on the night of the gala.

READ THIS ALOUD

The museum's windows blaze with light, and a string quartet is playing in the ballroom. Everyone who matters in Wrenfield is here, in their best clothes. In a glass case by the dinosaur, under a little card that says "Historic Hunting Jewellery, on loan from a private collection", lies a pendant shaped like a drop of water. Somewhere a girl named Isla Brook is sitting at home, unable to remember what it felt like to swim like an otter. You're going to bring it back to her.

What's Going On

The gala is how the Hunt shows off to its members and tempts new ones. Most guests are ordinary townsfolk who have no idea what the jewellery case really holds. A Huntsman stands by the case all evening, smiling at everyone. Two Hounds and a Trapper wait in the dark halls between the ballroom and the case. If the pendant leaves the building, its Bond can go home to Isla.

WHERE	OBSTACLE	TAGS	APPROACHES (DIFFICULTY)	KIND · PROGRESS	NOTES
Way in A	**The front doors**	Crowd	Sneak 3 · Wits 2	Group	—
Way in B	**The loading bay**	Dark, Locked	Sneak 3 · Force 3 · Wits 2	Point · 2	—
Inside 1	**The ballroom**	Crowd, Open	Sneak 2 · Wits 2	Group	—
Inside 2	**The dark exhibit halls**	Dark, High	Sneak 2 · Move 2 · Sense 3	Group	Guarded by 2 Hounds and a Trapper. Beating them clears it.
Objective	**The Trophy case**	Locked, Crowd	Force 3 · Wits 3	Point · 3	Guarded by a Huntsman. Clash first, then progress. A prize to carry out.
Escape 1	**The galleries**	Dark, High	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	—
Escape 2	**The museum steps**	Open, Crowd	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	—

Scent Limit: 6 with 3 players · 6 with 4 · 6 with 5. **Scouting:** Sense, Difficulty 2.

The Places

WAY IN A: THE FRONT DOORS

Guests arrive in a crowd at the front doors, past a man checking invitations. Kids in human form can talk their way in as somebody's children; an animal will cause a commotion.

WAY IN B: THE LOADING BAY

Round the side, in the dark, the caterers' loading bay has a roller shutter and a locked door into the kitchens behind the ballroom. One of you has to get it open.

INSIDE 1: THE BALLROOM

Chandeliers, a quartet, waiters with trays, and two hundred guests. Everyone has to cross it without being stopped. Blend in, or slip along the walls.

INSIDE 2: THE DARK EXHIBIT HALLS

Beyond the ballroom the museum is unlit: tall cases of stuffed animals, a mezzanine above, and two Hounds and a Trapper on watch. Everyone has to get through. If anyone Fails, it's a Clash.

THE OBJECTIVE: THE TROPHY CASE

The glass case stands under a spotlight in the Hall of Hunters, at the far end of the dark halls, beside the dinosaur. All evening the Huntsman beside it brings small groups of guests to admire it, so there's always a crowd. The lock is tricky and the glass is thick. If anyone Fails while the Huntsman is there, it's a Clash, and beating him doesn't open the case. When it opens, someone takes the pendant: it's a prize to carry out, small enough for jaws or a pocket. If its carrier is Taken, it's lost.

ESCAPE 1: THE GALLERIES

Back through the dark halls and along the upper galleries, with the gala starting to notice that something is wrong.

ESCAPE 2: THE MUSEUM STEPS

Out through a side door and down the wide front steps, into the open, past guests waiting for their cars.

Threats

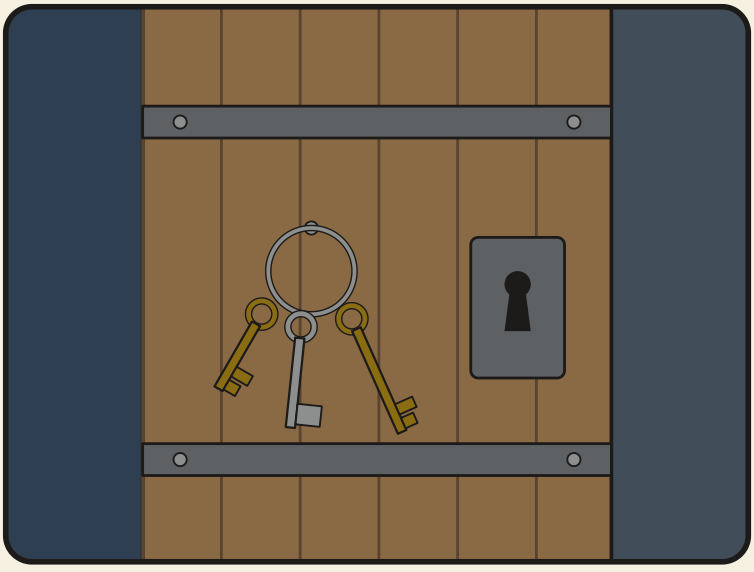
Two Hounds and **a Trapper** in the halls, and **a Huntsman** at the case (Chapter 10). If the Hunt is Up, Lady Cordelia Vane herself rises from her seat at the gala, and the doors begin to close.

SPOTLIGHTS

This is the Crowd mission. Canines and Critters blend in where Big Cats, Heavies and Reptiles can't, and kids in human form are at their best at the front doors and in the ballroom. Big Cats and Birds rule the dark, high halls. Plan who shifts when; there isn't much cover in a ballroom.

After the Mission

- **Win:** the pendant reaches Isla, and the next morning she's in the river, laughing. The Hunt knows the Bonded were at the gala.
- **Costly Win:** Isla gets her Bond back, but one of the team doesn't come home.
- **Loss:** the pendant goes back to the Lodge. Isla's Bond stays chained in gold until someone frees it.

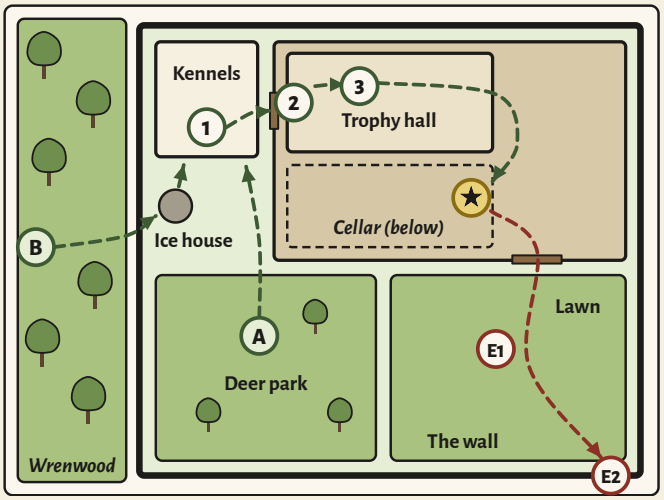




CHAPTER 17 · HARD MISSION

The Lodge on the Hill

A Bonded boy is caged in the cellar of the Lodge on Thornhill, the Hunt's own house. The team gets over the wall or under it, past the kennels and into the house, and breaks him out, along with any Taken friends of their own.



The Lodge on Thornhill and its grounds.

READ THIS ALOUD

Thornhill looks different at night. The Lodge sits at the top like a crouching animal, with one lit window high under the roof. Somewhere below it, in a cellar, is Kit Marsh: twelve years old, Bonded to a brown hare, and Taken on Tuesday walking home from school. In three nights the moon will be full, and the Hunt will make him into a Trophy. Not if you get there first.

What's Going On

The Lodge is Lady Cordelia Vane's house and the Hunt's home. It's heavily guarded: two Hounds in the deer park, three in the kennels, two Trappers in the cellar, and the Masters asleep upstairs.

Rescuing a friend: if one of your team was Taken on an earlier mission, they're in the cellar cage too. Free the cage and you free them both. A rescued character rejoins the team when you're out, but doesn't roll during the Escape.

WHERE	OBSTACLE	TAGS	APPROACHES (DIFFICULTY)	KIND · PROGRESS	NOTES
Way in A	**The deer park**	Open, Dark	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	Guarded by 2 Hounds. Beating them clears it.
Way in B	**The ice-house tunnel**	Narrow, Dark, Water	Sneak 2 · Move 2	Group	Dangerous: a Fail deals 1 Hurt.
Inside 1	**The kennels**	Narrow, Dark	Sneak 2 · Move 3 · Sense 3	Group	Guarded by 3 Hounds. Beating them clears it.
Inside 2	**The servants' door**	Locked	Force 3 · Wits 2	Point · 2	—
Inside 3	**The trophy hall**	High, Dark	Sense 2	Point · 2	—
Objective	**The cellar cage**	Locked, Narrow	Force 3 · Wits 2	Point · 3	Guarded by 2 Trappers. Clash first, then progress.
Escape 1	**The lawn**	Open	Sneak 3 · Move 2	Group	—
Escape 2	**The wall**	High	Force 3 · Move 2	Group	—

Scent Limit: 7 with 3 players · 7 with 4 · 7 with 5. **Scouting:** Sense, Difficulty 2.

The Places

WAY IN A: THE DEER PARK

A long, dark, open slope of grass and old oaks between the wall and the house, with two Hounds loose on it. Everyone has to cross. If anyone Fails, the Hounds come.

WAY IN B: THE ICE-HOUSE TUNNEL

An old brick tunnel runs from a forgotten ice house in Wrenwood up under the lawn, half flooded and very narrow. It's cold and the water is deep in places: a Fail deals 1 Hurt.

INSIDE 1: THE KENNELS

The way to the house runs past the kennels: a narrow, dark yard with three Hounds behind half-doors. Everyone has to get past without waking them. A patient watcher can learn their rhythm (Sense 3). If anyone Fails, it's a Clash.

INSIDE 2: THE SERVANTS' DOOR

The back door of the house, locked and bolted. Clever hands or a heavy shoulder.

INSIDE 3: THE TROPHY HALL

A long, dark hall hung with the Hunt's old Trophies in glass frames, with a gallery above. Somewhere in here is the way down to the cellar, behind a panel nobody is meant to find. Search, sniff, look.

THE OBJECTIVE: THE CELLAR CAGE

A narrow stone cellar with a gilded cage, and two Trappers playing cards at a table by the stairs. The cage is locked with three old locks. If anyone Fails while the Trappers are there, it's a Clash, and beating them doesn't open the cage: you still need 3 progress. When it opens, Kit (and any Taken friend of yours) comes with you. Kit is too weak to shift; he goes where you go, and doesn't roll.

ESCAPE 1: THE LAWN

Out through the garden door and across the wide front lawn, in full view of the house.

ESCAPE 2: THE WALL

The old wall around the grounds: climb it, fly it, or break through the rotten gate.

Threats

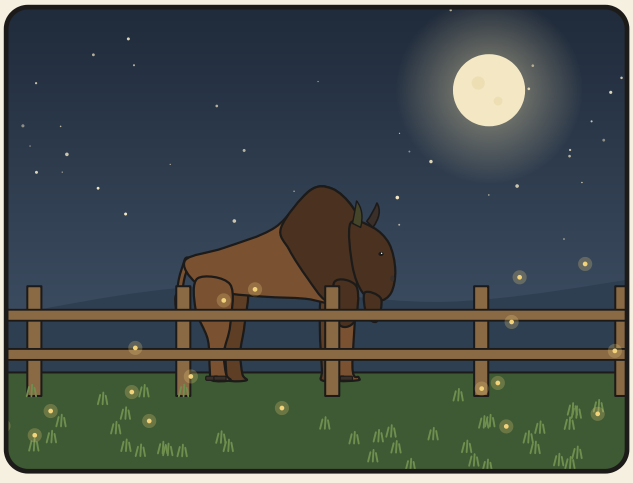
Two Hounds in the deer park, **three Hounds** in the kennels, and **two Trappers** in the cellar (Chapter 10). If the Hunt is Up, the Masters wake, and the lit window under the roof goes dark.

SPOTLIGHTS

Critters and Reptiles shine in the ice-house tunnel and the kennels; Canines and Heavies in the deer park and on the lawn; Birds and Big Cats in the trophy hall and on the wall. The servants' door and the cellar locks want hands, or a Heavy.

After the Mission

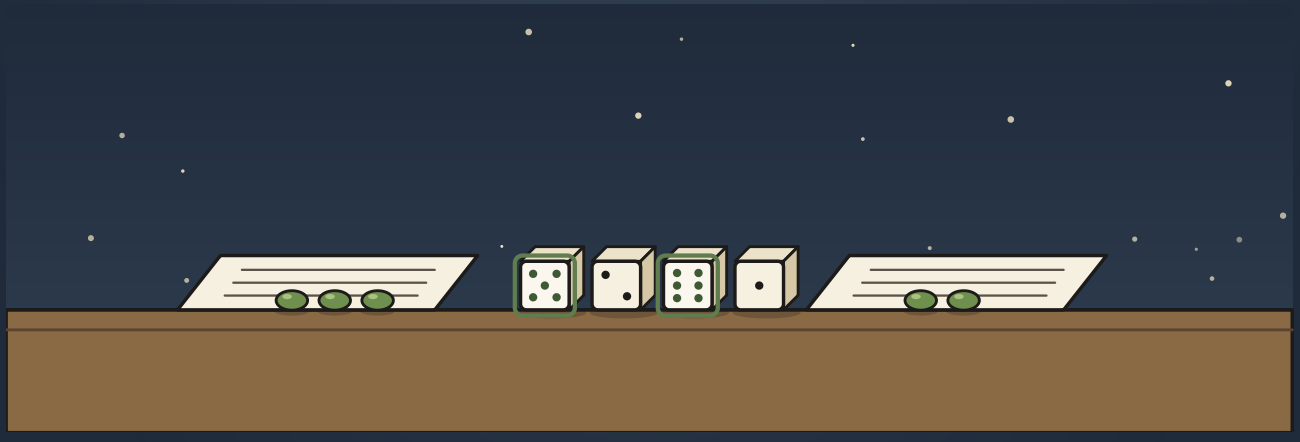
- **Win:** Kit is home by dawn, and his hare is back in Wrenwood. The Hunt has been beaten in its own house, and it won't forget it.
- **Costly Win:** Kit is free, but one of the team now sits in the cage he left. The full moon is still coming.
- **Loss:** the cellar stays locked. If nobody tries again before the full moon, Kit's Bond becomes a Trophy (Chapter 8).

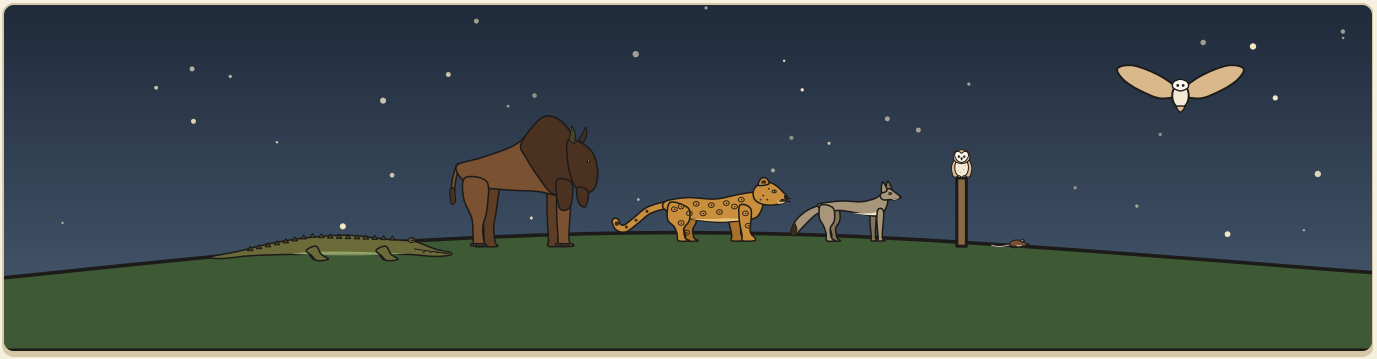


PART FOUR

Ready to Play

Six ready-made Bonded, the rules on one page, and the sheets to print.





CHAPTER 18

Ready-Made Bonded

Six Bonded from Wrenfield, one for each frame, ready to play tonight. Copy one onto a character sheet, or just play from this page. If two players want the same character, they each roll a die: the higher roll chooses first.

Maya Reyes, 12 · Jaguar



"If you can't see me, I'm doing it right."

Quiet, watchful, and the best hide-and-seek player Wrenfield Middle has ever had. Her jaguar found her on the wet roof of the garden centre on the night of the Waking. She loves the rooftop garden at the library.

Human: Sneak 3 · Force 1 · Move 2 · Sense 2 · Wits 1

Jaguar (Big Cats): Sneak 4 · Force 3 · Move 3 · Sense 2 · **Strengths:** Dark, High · **Weaknesses:** Water, Crowd

NIGHT ROSETTES (ANIMAL PERK)
In Dark places, your Sneak rolls are at –1 Difficulty.

HIDE-AND-SEEK CHAMP (HUMAN PERK)
+1 die on Sneak rolls.

Mark: a fleck of gold in her left eye · **Wild:** 4

Theo Park, 13 · Coyote



"Right. Plan. Everybody listen."

Captain of the junior football team, and the one who keeps everyone together. A coyote waited for him at the end of his street. He loves the football pitch in the park.

Human: Sneak 1 · Force 2 · Move 3 · Sense 1 · Wits 2

Coyote (Canines): Sneak 3 · Force 3 · Move 3 · Sense 4 · **Strengths:** Open, Crowd · **Weakness:** High

PACK (ANIMAL PERK)
Once per scene, Help without spending Wild.

TEAM CAPTAIN (HUMAN PERK)
The team starts every mission with 1 Edge.

Mark: a notch in his left ear · **Wild:** 4

Priya Shah, 11 · Barn Owl



"Actually, I read about this."

The youngest of the group, and the cleverest. Her barn owl landed on her bedroom windowsill and wouldn't leave. She loves Wrenfield Library, and Ms Quill.

Human: Sneak 1 · Force 1 · Move 2 · Sense 2 · Wits 3

Barn Owl (Birds): Sneak 2 · Force 1 · Move 4 · Sense 4 · **Strengths:** High, Open · **Weakness:** Narrow

SILENT WINGS (ANIMAL PERK)
In Dark places, +1 die on Sneak and Move rolls.

BRAINIAC (HUMAN PERK, HUMAN FORM)
+1 die on Wits rolls.

Mark: round glasses; as an owl, pale rings around her eyes · **Wild:** 4

Sam Lindqvist, 12 · Brown Rat



"I've got one life left. That's plenty."

Sam knows every shortcut in town and the high score on every machine in the arcade. His rat came up through the drain in his back yard. He loves the arcade on the High Street.

Human: Sneak 2 · Force 1 · Move 2 · Sense 3 · Wits 1

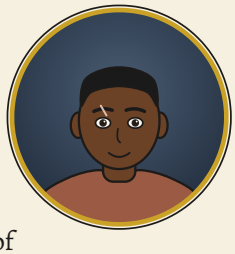
Brown Rat (Critters): Sneak 4 · Force 1 · Move 3 · Sense 3 · **Strengths:** Narrow, Crowd · **Weakness:** Open

GNAW (ANIMAL PERK)
Against Locked things, your Force rating is 3.

GAMER (HUMAN PERK)
Start every mission with 1 extra Wild.

Mark: a white streak in his fringe; as a rat, a white patch between his ears · **Wild:** 5

Jonah Mensah, 14 · Bison



"Stand behind me."

The oldest and the biggest, and gentle with it. A bison, impossibly, stood in the middle of the bypass on the night of the Waking and looked at him for a whole minute. He loves the chip shop.

Human: Sneak 1 · Force 3 · Move 2 · Sense 1 · Wits 2

Bison (Heavies): Sneak 2 · Force 4 · Move 3 · Sense 3 · **Strengths:** Open, Locked · **Weaknesses:** Narrow, Crowd

SHAGGY COAT (ANIMAL PERK)
Once per scene, when you'd take Hurt, take 1 less.

FOOTBALL PLAYER (HUMAN PERK)
+1 die on Force rolls.

Mark: a scar through his right eyebrow; as a bison, a pale scar over his right eye · **Wild:** 4

Lucía Ortega, 13 · Alligator



"Nobody ever expects the river."

Swim team, debate club, and never short of a story. Her alligator surfaced in the River Wren, where no alligator has any business being. She loves the river path behind the Old Mill.

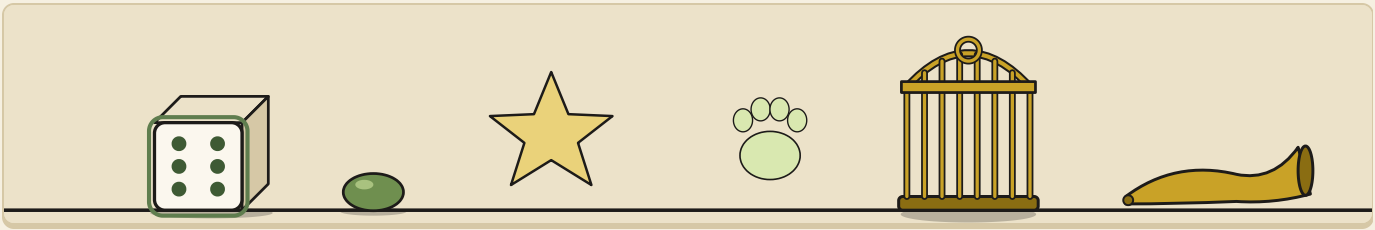
Human: Sneak 2 · Force 1 · Move 3 · Sense 1 · Wits 2

Alligator (Reptiles): Sneak 3 · Force 3 · Move 3 · Sense 3 · **Strengths:** Water, Dark · **Weakness:** Crowd

LURKER (ANIMAL PERK)
In Water, your Sneak and Force rolls are at –1 Difficulty.

SWIM TEAM (HUMAN PERK)
+1 die on rolls in Water.

Mark: freckles across her nose; as an alligator, pale spots on her snout · **Wild:** 4



CHAPTER 19

At the Table

THE WHOLE GAME ON ONE PAGE, FOR THE MIDDLE OF the table. Every rule here is explained in full in the chapter given in brackets.

THE ROLL (CH. 3)

Roll your rating in the approach (your current form), plus bonus dice. **5 or 6 = hit.** Difficulty = hits needed. **Fail:** no hits. **Partial:** some hits, fewer than the Difficulty. **Success:** enough hits. **Critical:** a Success with two or more 6s. **The Cap:** at most +2 dice and –1 Difficulty per roll, from all sources. Threats never roll.

WILD (CH. 3, 4, 7)

Start each mission with 4 (5 for a Gamer). Spend 1 to: **Shift** into your animal (your action); **Push** (reroll every miss, once per roll, not limited by the Cap); **Help** a friend's roll (+1 die, no action; your form must be able to do it); **Patch Up** 1 Hurt (your action). Unspent Wild is lost. **Edges** (team, at most 2): +1 die on any roll.

SHIFTING (CH. 4)

Into your animal: 1 Wild (or 1 Hurt if you have none) and your action. Back: free, your action. No time limit. Between obstacles, everyone may Shift or Patch Up once for free; that's out of sight. A shift in a Clash is in sight: you're Exposed. Animals can't talk, read, use tools or roll Wits; they carry one small thing. Strength in a place's tags: +1 die. Weakness: +1 Difficulty.

OBSTACLES (CH. 5)

Point: one roll per round, by anyone; progress adds up. **Group:** everyone not yet past rolls; Partial or better gets you past. **Success:** 1 progress. **Critical:** +1 extra progress, or an Edge. **Partial:** 1 progress, Scent +1. **Fail:** no progress, Scent +1; dangerous: 1 Hurt; guarded: a Clash. A group obstacle raises Scent once, when it ends (+1 for any Partial or Fail), and +1 for every round after the third. In the Escape, Partials cost no Scent.

CLASHES (CH. 6)

Each round, everyone acts once: **Strike** (Force; Success 1 harm, Critical 2), **Distract** (Sneak or Move; next Strike on it this round –1 Difficulty), **Slip Away** (Move or Sneak; you're out and past), Shift, Patch Up, or free a Netted friend. Partial: it works, but you take the threat's Harm. Fail: you take its Harm. Each threat nobody rolled against hurts someone. Ends when all threats are out, nobody's left, or after round 4. Then Scent +1, or +2 if it reached round 4, someone went Down, or someone shifted.

SCENT AND THE HUNT (CH. 5)

Scent never goes down. **On the Trail** (half the Limit or more, rounded up, as an Escape obstacle begins): that obstacle is +1 Difficulty. **The Hunt is Up** (at the Limit): any Fail means you're Taken; keep going or Withdraw (a Loss).

HURT AND WORSE (CH. 7)

3 Hurt boxes; Hurt never lowers your dice. **Down** at 3: out until the scene ends, then back up with 2 Hurt if a friend stands and the Hunt isn't Up; otherwise Taken. Down as an animal: **Stuck**. **Netted** (a Trapper on your Fail): a friend frees you, or you're freed at scene end on the same terms. **Taken:** out for the mission; the prize is lost with you. **Exposed:** next mission starts at Scent 1. Everyone down at once: everyone Taken.

A MISSION (CH. 5)

Scout (Sense 2: Critical = pick the way in, 2 Edges; Success = pick, 1 Edge; Partial = pick, Scent 1; Fail = Storyteller picks, Scent 1) → way in → obstacles → objective → Escape. **Win:** done, nobody Taken. **Costly Win:** done, someone Taken. **Loss:** not done.

Character Sheet

One per player. Fill it in with a pencil: Wild, Hurt and Growth change during play.

Name _____

Age _____

Frame _____

Animal _____

Mark _____

I love... _____

FORM	SNEAK	FORCE	MOVE	SENSE	WITS
HUMAN					
ANIMAL					0

STRENGTHS (+1 DIE)	WEAKNESSES (+1 DIFFICULTY)

ANIMAL PERK (ANIMAL FORM ONLY)	HUMAN PERK

WILD (START: 4)	HURT (3 = DOWN)	NOW I'M...
○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○	☐ Human ☐ Animal ☐ Stuck ☐ Netted ☐ Exposed

GROWTH (CH. 8)	AT 2	AT 4	AT 6
○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○			

NOTES: SIGNALS WE AGREED, THINGS WE FOUND, PEOPLE WE MET

Spend Wild to Shift (1), Push (1), Help (1) or Patch Up (1). Unspent Wild is lost at the end of the mission.

Mission Tracker

One for the table, where everyone can see it. Put a marker on the Scent track and circle the mission's Limit for your number of players.

Mission _____

Players _____

Limit _____

Half the Limit (On the Trail) _____

SCENT (NEVER GOES DOWN)									
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9

On the Trail: Scent at least half the Limit (round up) when an Escape obstacle begins → that obstacle is +1 Difficulty. The Hunt is Up at the Limit → any Fail means Taken.

EDGES (AT MOST 2)	WAY IN	OBJECTIVE DONE?	PRIZE CARRIED BY
◯ ◯	☐ A ☐ B	☐ Yes	

TAKEN THIS MISSION	EXPOSED THIS MISSION

CAMPAIGN: THE HUNT TRACK (WIN +0 · COSTLY WIN +1 · LOSS +2; AT 6 THE LAST HUNT COMES EARLY)						
0	1	2	3	4	5	6

MISSIONS PLAYED AND RESULTS

Storyteller's Round Card

Keep this in front of you. You never roll; you describe, set Difficulties and keep the Scent track.

AN OBSTACLE	
1	**Describe it** and its tags. Say which approaches work and their Difficulties, and whether it's point or group, guarded or dangerous.
2	**Point:** one player rolls this round; others may Help. **Group:** everyone not yet past rolls.
3	**Resolve:** Success = progress; Critical = +1 progress or an Edge; Partial = progress and Scent +1 (point obstacles); Fail = no progress and Scent +1, plus Hurt if dangerous, plus a Clash if guarded (or Taken if the Hunt is Up).
4	**Group obstacle ending?** Scent +1 if anyone got a Partial or Fail (only Fails in the Escape). Still going after round 3? Scent +1 every round.
5	**Scene over:** Down and Netted friends get up (2 Hurt) if anyone is standing and the Hunt isn't Up; otherwise they're Taken. Once-per-scene abilities come back.

A CLASH ROUND	
1	Everyone takes one action, in any order they like: Strike, Distract, Slip Away, Shift, Patch Up, free a friend. Help can come at any time.
2	Resolve each roll as it's made. Partial: it works, and the threat's Harm hits them. Fail: Harm only (a Trapper nets instead).
3	Each threat nobody rolled against hurts one character of your choice.
4	Ended? (All threats out, nobody left, or round 4 done.) Then Scent +1, or +2 if it reached round 4, someone went Down, or someone shifted (they're Exposed).

THREAT	DIFFICULTY	TOUGHNESS	HARM	SPECIAL
Beater	2	2	1	—
Hound	2	3	1	Tracker: Sneak +1 Difficulty where it guards
Trapper	2	2	1	Net: a Fail against it nets you
Huntsman	3	4	2	Trophy: Sneak +1 Difficulty where it guards

THREATS IN THIS CLASH: HARM TAKEN